NORTHSTAR DIGITAL SERVICES LTD.

People Operations · Finance · Information Security

Employee Handbook

Policies and procedures for everyone who works at Northstar

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Applies to	All employees, managers, People Operations, Finance, IT, leadership
Jurisdiction	England and Wales
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Document control

Approval and ownership

Document approval block — Employee Handbook NDS-HR-HB-001

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Revision history

Revision history — Employee Handbook NDS-HR-HB-001

Version	Effective date	Summary of changes
1.0	1 January 2025	First consolidated handbook following the merger of the Manchester and Leeds operating entities.
1.1	1 July 2025	Updated whistleblowing contacts; added the sexual harassment prevention duty under the Worker Protection (Amendment of Equality Act 2010) Act 2023.
2.0	1 October 2026	Major revision. Annual leave increased from 25 to 27 days; new service-related leave increments; hourly leave introduced; carryover limit increased to 5 days; sickness reporting deadline moved to 09:30; Statutory Sick Pay changes from 6 April 2026 reflected; day-one paternity leave and unpaid parental leave reflected; new generative AI rules; hybrid attendance standard of 8 office days per 4-week period; expense limits revised; new supporting standards issued.

Related current documents

This handbook summarises Northstar's people policies. Where a supporting standard contains more detail, the supporting standard is the authoritative detailed rule for that topic (see section 1.5).

Current supporting documents referenced in this handbook

Document ID	Title	Version	Owner
NDS-HR-LAS-002	Leave and Absence Standard	1.2	Director of People Operations
NDS-FIN-EXP-003	Expenses and Business Travel Policy	1.1	Finance Director
NDS-SEC-ITG-004	IT Security, Data Protection and Generative AI Policy	2.0	Chief Information Security Officer (CISO)
NDS-HR-HFW-005	Hybrid and Flexible Working Standard	1.1	Head of Workplace Experience

Superseded material

The Leave Policy NDS-HR-LV-006 v1.0 (effective 1 January 2025 to 30 September 2026) is archived. It is retained for historical reference only and must not be used for decisions about leave taken, requested or calculated on or after 1 October 2026, except where section 6.15 of this handbook expressly applies a transitional rule.

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1 Introduction and document governance

1.1 Purpose and scope

This Employee Handbook (document ID NDS-HR-HB-001, version 2.0) sets out how Northstar Digital Services Ltd. ("Northstar", "the company") manages employment, conduct, leave, pay, working arrangements, information security and related matters. It applies from 1 October 2026 and will be reviewed by 1 October 2027.

The handbook is written for employees, people managers, department leaders, People Operations, Finance, IT and senior leadership. It explains what the company expects, what employees can expect from the company, and where to find the detailed procedure for each topic.

The handbook is a summary. Where a current supporting standard deals with the same topic in more detail, the supporting standard is the authoritative detailed rule and this handbook should be read together with it.

1.2 Who the handbook applies to

Table 1.2 — Application of this handbook by worker category

Category	Employee?	How the handbook applies
Permanent full-time employees	Yes	All sections apply.
Permanent part-time employees	Yes	All sections apply; entitlements expressed in days or hours are pro-rated as described in each section.
Fixed-term employees	Yes	All sections apply for the duration of the fixed term, unless a section states otherwise. Fixed-term employees must not be treated less favourably than comparable permanent employees without objective justification.
Apprentices	Yes	All sections apply, together with the apprenticeship agreement and training plan.
Interns (paid, on a contract of employment)	Yes	All sections apply for the internship period.
Contractors engaged through a personal service company or consultancy	No	Only sections 4, 14, 16, 17, 18, 19 and 20 apply as conditions of engagement and site access. Contractors are governed by their contract for services.
Agency workers	No (worker of the agency)	Sections 4, 14, 16, 17, 18, 19 and 20 apply. Statutory agency-worker rights, including equal treatment on basic working and employment conditions after 12 weeks in the same role, are handled with the agency.

A person's status is determined by the reality of the working relationship and not simply by the label in a contract. If a manager is unsure whether someone is an employee, worker or self-employed contractor, they must contact People Operations before agreeing any working arrangement.

1.3 Definitions and terminology

Table 1.3 — Defined terms used in Northstar policies

Term	Meaning
Annual leave	Paid time away from work that an employee books in advance. Also described by employees as holiday, vacation, PTO or time off. Annual leave does not include bank holidays unless stated.
Bank holiday	A public holiday in England and Wales as listed in section 6.5. Also called public holiday.
Leave year	1 January to 31 December.
Working day	Monday to Friday, excluding bank holidays in England and Wales, unless an employee's contract specifies a different working pattern.
Full-time equivalent (FTE)	Contracted weekly hours divided by 37.5. A full-time employee is 1.0 FTE.
Continuous service	The period of continuous employment with Northstar (and any predecessor entity where service has been recognised in writing), counted in completed calendar months or years.
Line manager	The person to whom the employee reports on the PeopleHub organisation chart.
Head of Department (HoD)	The senior leader responsible for a department or practice.
Director	A member of the Northstar leadership team at grade G6 or above.
PeopleHub	Northstar's HR information system used to request leave, report absence, view payslips and update personal details.
TimeTrack	Northstar's time-recording system.
ExpenseFlow	Northstar's expenses system.
Critical delivery period	A period designated by a Head of Department in which leave is restricted to protect a customer deployment, go-live, audit or year-end activity (see section 6.7).
Supporting standard	A detailed, topic-specific policy listed in the Document control section.

1.4 Contractual terms, statutory rights, company policies and manager guidance

Northstar's rules come from four different sources, and it matters which one applies:

- **Statutory rights** are legal requirements set by legislation, such as the minimum 5.6 weeks' paid holiday, Statutory Sick Pay and the right to request flexible working. They apply whether or not they are written into this handbook, and no Northstar policy, contract or manager decision can reduce them.
- **Contractual terms** are set out in the employee's written statement of particulars, contract of employment and any written contractual variation. Examples include salary, notice periods and the company sick pay scheme where the contract incorporates it.
- **Company policies** are non-contractual rules and procedures that Northstar may update from time to time following appropriate consultation. Unless a policy expressly states that it is contractual, it does not form part of the contract of employment.
- **Manager guidance** is practical, non-binding advice that helps managers apply policies consistently. Guidance cannot create a new entitlement or remove an existing one.

> **Company enhancements never replace statutory rights**
> Where this handbook describes a company enhancement (for example, company sick pay or enhanced maternity pay), the enhancement is in addition to, or inclusive of, the statutory entitlement. It never replaces or reduces a mandatory statutory entitlement. Where an employee does not meet the conditions for a company enhancement, their statutory entitlement still applies if they meet the statutory conditions.

1.5 Policy hierarchy and conflict resolution

If two sources appear to conflict, apply the following order of precedence, subject always to mandatory law:

1. Applicable mandatory law.
2. The employee's applicable employment contract or written contractual variation.
3. The current, topic-specific approved policy or standard (for example, the Leave and Absence Standard NDS-HR-LAS-002).
4. This current Employee Handbook summary.
5. Non-binding manager guidance.

A superseded or archived document never takes precedence over a current document. Archived documents are retained only to show what applied during their effective period. When a question concerns a past date, use the document whose effective period covers that date; when it concerns a current or future date, use the current document.

If an employee or manager identifies a genuine conflict between current documents, they should apply the higher-ranked source and report the conflict to people@northstar.example so that the documents can be corrected.

1.6 Ownership, approval and review

Table 1.6 — Policy ownership and approval

Document	Owner	Approval authority
Employee Handbook (NDS-HR-HB-001)	Director of People Operations	Executive Leadership Team
Leave and Absence Standard (NDS-HR-LAS-002)	Director of People Operations	Executive Leadership Team
Expenses and Business Travel Policy (NDS-FIN-EXP-003)	Finance Director	Chief Financial Officer
IT Security, Data Protection and Generative AI Policy (NDS-SEC-ITG-004)	Chief Information Security Officer	Executive Leadership Team, with Data Protection Officer sign-off
Hybrid and Flexible Working Standard (NDS-HR-HFW-005)	Head of Workplace Experience	Director of People Operations

Every current policy is reviewed at least once every 12 months, and earlier when the law changes, when an audit identifies a gap, or when the business changes materially. Changes are recorded in the revision history of each document. The effective date shown in a document's control block is the date from which its rules apply; the date a file was last saved or modified is not the effective date.

1.7 Effective date, versions and change log

This version 2.0 is effective from 1 October 2026. The previous handbook (version 1.1) applied from 1 July 2025 to 30 September 2026. A summary of changes appears in the Document control section at the front of this handbook and in Appendix H.

1.8 Jurisdiction

This handbook is written for employees employed under contracts governed by the law of England and Wales. Northstar currently employs a small number of people based in Scotland and Northern Ireland. Some employment rules differ in those jurisdictions — for example, bank holidays, aspects of family leave and parental bereavement eligibility in Northern Ireland, and certain procedural rules. Where a section is marked **[E&W]**, the rule is specific to England and Wales and People Operations will arrange local policy or legal review before applying it to an employee based in Scotland or Northern Ireland.

1.9 Finding help

Most questions can be answered by this handbook or the relevant supporting standard. If not:

1. Speak to your line manager.
2. Search the People Operations knowledge base on the intranet.
3. Contact People Operations at people@northstar.example or raise a PeopleHub case.
4. For pay questions contact payroll@northstar.example; for IT questions contact ithelp@northstar.example.

The full contact and escalation directory is in Appendix B.

1.10 Reporting an error or requesting clarification

If you find an error, an out-of-date reference or an unclear rule, raise a PeopleHub case using the category "Policy clarification" or email people@northstar.example. People Operations will acknowledge the request within 5 working days. Clarifications that change how a rule is applied are published as a dated policy note and incorporated at the next review.

1.11 Exceptions

Exceptions to non-statutory policy rules may be considered in individual cases. The rules for who may approve an exception, how long it lasts and how it is recorded are set out in section 23. An exception is never automatic, must be recorded in writing, and cannot override mandatory law.

2 Employment categories and working arrangements

2.1 Employment categories

Table 2.1 — Employment categories and key differences

Category	Typical contract	Probation	Notable eligibility differences
Permanent full-time	Open-ended, 37.5 hours per week	6 months	Full entitlements.
Permanent part-time	Open-ended, fewer than 37.5 hours per week	6 months	Pro-rated leave, benefits and allowances expressed in days, hours or money where pro-rating is appropriate.
Fixed-term	Defined end date or end of a specified project	6 months, or one-third of the fixed term if shorter (rounded up to the nearest whole month)	Same entitlements as comparable permanent employees, pro-rated for the length of the term.
Apprentice	Apprenticeship agreement of at least 12 months	3 months	Includes protected off-the-job training time as required by the applicable apprenticeship programme rules.
Intern	Fixed-term employment contract, typically 10 to 12 weeks	None; reviewed at the mid-point	Paid at least the applicable National Minimum Wage rate; leave accrues pro rata.
Contractor	Contract for services	Not applicable	Not eligible for employee benefits, company sick pay or company leave enhancements.
Agency worker	Engaged through an agency	Not applicable	Rights managed with the agency; access to shared facilities and vacancy information from day one.

2.2 Employees and non-employees

Only employees have access to employee benefits such as company sick pay, enhanced family pay, the learning budget and the pension scheme. Contractors and agency workers must not be managed as if they were employees: for example, they should not be given annual performance ratings, offered company benefits, or required to follow the leave request process in PeopleHub. Questions about engagement status must go to People Operations before any change is made.

2.3 Probation

New permanent employees serve a probation period of **6 months** from their start date. Probation allows both the employee and Northstar to confirm that the role is a good fit.

Table 2.3 — Probation timeline for permanent employees

Point	What happens	Responsibility
Week 1	Induction completed and objectives for probation agreed in PeopleHub.	Line manager
End of month 1	First probation review meeting; written notes recorded.	Line manager
End of month 3	Mid-point review; concerns identified in writing with support offered.	Line manager, with People Operations if concerns exist
End of month 5	Pre-final review; manager confirms likely outcome.	Line manager
By end of month 6	Final review and written confirmation of the outcome: passed, extended, or not passed.	Line manager and People Operations

Probation may be extended **once**, by up to **3 months**, where the manager needs more time to assess performance or where absence has affected the assessment. The extension must be confirmed in writing before the original probation end date. If no written outcome is issued by the end of the original 6-month period, the employee should contact People Operations; probation is not automatically passed or failed.

During probation, the notice period on either side is **1 week**. Annual leave during probation is covered in section 6.16 and company sick pay during probation in section 7.5.

If probation is not passed, the manager must hold a meeting with the employee, explain the reasons, give the employee an opportunity to respond, and confirm the outcome in writing. The employee may appeal in writing to People Operations within **5 working days** of the outcome letter.

2.4 Changes to working hours

An employee who wants to change their contracted hours may use the statutory flexible working procedure (section 10.6) or, for a short-term change, request a temporary arrangement (section 10.7). Changes to hours take effect only once confirmed in writing by People Operations. Where hours change part-way through a leave year, annual leave is recalculated using the method in section 6.3.

2.5 Internal transfers, temporary assignments, job titles and reporting lines

- **Internal transfers** require agreement from both the releasing and receiving Heads of Department. The standard release period is 1 month, unless both agree otherwise.
- **Temporary assignments** (for example, a secondment to a customer programme) last no longer than 6 months unless extended in writing. Pay and terms remain unchanged unless a written variation is issued.
- **Job titles and grades** are set by People Operations using the Northstar job architecture (grades G1 to G7). Managers may not create new titles without approval.
- **Reporting line changes** are recorded in PeopleHub by People Operations. Employees will be told in writing about any change to their line manager.

- **Role changes** that alter duties, grade, pay, location or hours materially are contractual changes and require consultation and written agreement.

Table 2.5 — Northstar job architecture grades (illustrative)

Grade	Typical roles	Contractual notice after probation
G1	Associate, Apprentice (post-probation), Support Analyst	1 month
G2	Engineer, Consultant, Analyst	1 month
G3	Senior Engineer, Senior Consultant	1 month
G4	Lead Engineer, Principal Consultant	2 months
G5	Engineering Manager, Head of Practice	2 months
G6	Director	3 months
G7	Executive Leadership Team	3 months

3 Recruitment, selection and onboarding

3.1 Recruitment approvals and advertising

Every new or replacement role requires an approved headcount request in PeopleHub before advertising. Approval comes from the Head of Department and Finance Business Partner, and from a Director for any role at grade G4 or above. Roles are normally advertised internally for at least 5 working days before or alongside external advertising, unless a Director approves direct external recruitment (for example, for a specialist customer requirement).

Job adverts must describe the essential requirements of the role, avoid unnecessary requirements (such as a fixed number of years' experience where skills are what matter), state whether the role is hybrid, and include Northstar's commitment to reasonable adjustments.

3.2 Interviews and selection

- Every interview panel includes at least two people, at least one of whom has completed Northstar's inclusive recruitment training.
- Candidates are assessed against the same published criteria using structured questions and a written scoring record.
- Interview notes are retained in the recruitment system for the period set out in the retention schedule (section 18.4).
- Panel members must declare any conflict of interest, including a personal relationship with a candidate (see section 14.3).

3.3 Reasonable adjustments in recruitment

All candidates are asked whether they need adjustments at any stage. Examples include extra time for technical tests, a screen-reader-compatible assessment, a sign language interpreter, or an interview by video rather than in person. Requests are handled by the Talent Acquisition team and are not shared with the panel beyond what is needed to provide the adjustment.

3.4 Pre-employment checks

Table 3.4 — Pre-employment checks and timing

Check	When it must be completed	If it is delayed or incomplete
Right to work in the UK	Before the first day of employment. No exceptions.	The start date must be postponed. A person cannot start work until a compliant right-to-work check has been completed.
References (two, covering at least the last 3 years)	Before the start date where possible	The employee may start, with the offer conditional on satisfactory references. People Operations follows up.
Northstar Standard Screening (identity, employment history, basic criminal record check where the role requires it)	Before access to Confidential or Restricted customer systems	The employee may start with Internal-only access for up to 20 working days with Head of Department approval. If screening is still incomplete after 20 working days, the case is escalated to the Director of People Operations.
Customer-specific security clearance	As required by the customer contract	The employee must not work on that customer's systems until clearance is confirmed.
Professional qualifications (where essential to the role)	Before the start date	The offer may be withdrawn if an essential qualification cannot be verified.

3.5 Offer letters and pre-employment documentation

Offers are made verbally by Talent Acquisition and confirmed in an offer letter generated from PeopleHub. The written statement of employment particulars is issued no later than the first day of employment. New starters must complete their PeopleHub profile (address, bank details, emergency contact, tax information) no later than 5 working days before their start date so that they can be included in the correct payroll (see section 11.2). Missing documentation is chased by People Operations; missing bank or tax details may delay the first payment until the following payroll.

3.6 Onboarding, induction and access provisioning

- **Before day one:** the line manager raises an access request via the IT Service Desk at least 10 working days before the start date, specifying the systems and data classification required.
- **Day one:** the new starter collects their laptop and access card (or receives them by courier for remote starters), completes security setup including multifactor authentication, and meets their line manager.
- **Week one:** corporate induction, mandatory training (information security, data protection, equality and respect at work, health and safety, anti-bribery and acceptable use of generative AI) and probation objective-setting.
- **Within 30 days:** all mandatory training must be completed. Access to Confidential or Restricted data may be suspended if mandatory security training is not completed within 30 days.

3.7 Internal candidates

Internal candidates apply through the internal vacancies page. They should tell their line manager before an interview, but the line manager cannot block an application. Employees in probation or on a final written warning may apply only with People Operations' agreement. Unsuccessful internal candidates are offered feedback.

3.8 Failed or extended probation

Section 2.3 sets out the probation process. Managers must not wait until the final week to raise concerns: concerns must be documented at the month 1 or month 3 review where they arise. If probation is not passed, employment ends with 1 week's notice (or pay in lieu of notice) unless the statutory notice entitlement is greater.

4 Equality, diversity, inclusion and respectful conduct

4.1 Equal opportunities

Northstar is committed to equal opportunities in recruitment, pay, promotion, training, discipline and dismissal. We do not discriminate because of the protected characteristics set out in the Equality Act 2010: age, disability, gender reassignment, marriage and civil partnership, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief, sex and sexual orientation.

4.2 Unacceptable behaviour

Table 4.2 — Forms of unacceptable behaviour

Behaviour	Description and example
Direct discrimination	Treating someone less favourably because of a protected characteristic. Example: not shortlisting a candidate because they mentioned they are pregnant.
Indirect discrimination	Applying a rule that puts people with a protected characteristic at a particular disadvantage without objective justification. Example: requiring all team meetings to start at 08:00 when this disadvantages employees with caring responsibilities and there is no business need.
Harassment	Unwanted conduct related to a protected characteristic, or of a sexual nature, that violates dignity or creates an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment. Example: repeated jokes about a colleague's accent in a team chat.
Sexual harassment	Unwanted conduct of a sexual nature. Northstar takes proactive steps to prevent sexual harassment, including by third parties such as customers.
Bullying	Offensive, intimidating, malicious or insulting behaviour, or abuse of power, that undermines or humiliates. Example: a lead engineer repeatedly criticising a junior colleague in front of customers.
Victimisation	Treating someone badly because they made, supported or gave evidence about a complaint. Example: removing someone from a project after they raised a grievance.

> **Preventing sexual harassment**
> Since 26 October 2024, employers have had a duty to take reasonable steps to prevent sexual harassment of their employees. The Employment Rights Act 2025 strengthens this to a duty to take "all reasonable steps" and extends protection to harassment by third parties. At the date checked for this handbook, the strengthened duty was expected to commence on 30 October 2026. Northstar's training, risk assessments and reporting routes are designed to meet the strengthened duty. See the References section.

4.3 Reasonable adjustments

Northstar makes reasonable adjustments for disabled candidates and employees to remove or reduce disadvantages. Adjustments may include changes to working hours, equipment, location, duties, or procedures. Adjustments can be requested by the employee or suggested by a manager or Occupational Health. The line manager is responsible for agreeing and implementing adjustments with People Operations' support; reasonable costs are funded centrally from the People Operations adjustments budget, not from the team budget. Agreed adjustments are recorded in a confidential Workplace Adjustment Passport so that they move with the employee if they change role or manager.

4.4 Inclusive communication, religion, belief and culture

- Use names and pronouns colleagues ask you to use.
- Avoid scheduling mandatory team events on major religious festivals where possible; where unavoidable, offer an alternative.
- Employees may request time for prayer within working hours, using flexible start, finish and break times. The Manchester office has a quiet room available to all.
- Requests for leave for religious festivals are considered under section 6.6 and section 9.10.

- Dress code requirements must be applied in a way that accommodates religious and cultural dress unless there is a genuine health and safety reason.

4.5 Reporting concerns

Employees can raise concerns informally or formally:

- **Informal:** speak to the person directly if you feel able, or ask your line manager, a People Operations partner or a Respect at Work Contact to help resolve the matter informally.
- **Formal:** raise a written grievance under section 15.6, or, where the concern involves wrongdoing in the public interest, use the whistleblowing procedure in section 16.
- **Anonymous:** the independent Speak Up line (section 16.3) accepts anonymous reports. Anonymous reports can be harder to investigate because follow-up questions cannot always be asked.

Concerns about harassment by a customer or third party are reported in the same way and are also covered by section 21.

4.6 Investigation principles, confidentiality and retaliation

Complaints are investigated promptly, impartially and by someone with no involvement in the matter. Investigations are kept as confidential as possible, but confidentiality cannot be guaranteed absolutely: information may need to be shared with the person complained about, witnesses, decision-makers and, where legally required, external bodies. Anyone who raises a concern in good faith, or who supports an investigation, is protected from retaliation. Retaliation is a disciplinary offence and may amount to gross misconduct.

4.7 Escalation

If a concern involves your line manager, raise it with your Head of Department or People Operations. If it involves a Head of Department or Director, raise it with the Director of People Operations. If it involves the Director of People Operations, raise it with the Chief Executive Officer or the Speak Up line.

5 Working hours, attendance and time recording

5.1 Standard working week

The standard full-time working week is **37.5 hours**, worked Monday to Friday as **7.5 hours per day** excluding an unpaid lunch break of 60 minutes. The standard day is 09:00 to 17:30, but employees may vary their start and finish times within the flexible band of **07:30 to 19:00**, provided they are available during the core hours of **10:00 to 16:00** and their team's coverage arrangements are met.

Part-time employees work the hours and days set out in their contract. Their core-hours expectation applies only on their contracted working days and only for the hours they are contracted to work.

5.2 Breaks and rest

> **Working time minimums [E&W]**
> Under the Working Time Regulations 1998, adult workers are normally entitled to a rest break of at least 20 minutes when working more than 6 hours in a day, 11 consecutive hours' rest in each 24-hour period, and 24 hours' uninterrupted rest each week (or 48 hours each fortnight). Average weekly working time must not exceed 48 hours, normally averaged over 17 weeks, unless the worker has voluntarily opted out in writing. Different rules apply to young workers.

Northstar's 60-minute unpaid lunch break exceeds the statutory minimum. Employees may opt out of the 48-hour average limit by signing the voluntary opt-out form; they may withdraw the opt-out by giving 4 weeks' written notice. No employee will be treated detrimentally for refusing to opt out.

5.3 Attendance and punctuality

Employees must be available during their agreed hours and must tell their line manager as early as possible if they will be late or unavailable. Repeated lateness is handled first through an informal conversation and then, if it continues, through the disciplinary procedure. Absence because of illness must be reported using the sickness procedure in section 7, not as lateness.

5.4 Time recording

All employees who work on customer-billable or capitalised projects must record their time in TimeTrack.

- Time must be recorded daily and submitted by **12:00 (noon) each Monday** for the previous week.
- Time must be recorded against the correct project code in increments of **0.25 hours**.
- Line managers must approve or query submitted timesheets by **17:00 each Tuesday**.
- Employees are personally responsible for the accuracy of their timesheets. Knowingly recording false time is misconduct and, where it results in incorrect customer billing, may be gross misconduct.
- If an employee cannot submit on time (for example, because of absence), their line manager submits on their behalf with the comment "submitted by manager", and the employee confirms it on return.

5.5 Overtime and time off in lieu (TOIL)

Overtime is work beyond contracted hours that the line manager has approved **in advance**. Unapproved extra hours are not paid and do not earn TOIL, except where work was required in a genuine emergency (for example, a Severity 1 incident) and the manager confirms it within 2 working days.

Table 5.5 — Overtime compensation by grade

Grade	Compensation	Rate
G1 to G3	Paid overtime or TOIL, at the employee's choice	Paid at 1.5 x basic hourly rate on weekdays and Saturdays, and 2 x basic hourly rate on Sundays and bank holidays. TOIL is earned hour for hour.
G4 and G5	TOIL only	Hour for hour.
G6 and G7	No overtime or TOIL	Salary reflects the expectation of flexible hours.

The basic hourly rate is annual basic salary divided by 1,950 (52 weeks x 37.5 hours). A TOIL balance must not exceed **15 hours** at any time, and TOIL must be taken within **3 calendar months** of being earned. TOIL not taken within 3 months lapses unless the line manager refused a TOIL request for business reasons, in which case it may be extended once by a further 3 months. TOIL is not paid out on termination unless it was earned in the final 3 months of employment and could not be taken.

5.6 On-call support

Employees on an approved on-call rota receive a standby allowance and are compensated for call-outs.

Table 5.6 — On-call allowances (G1 to G5)

Item	Amount	Condition
Standby, weekday night (17:30 to 09:00)	£30 per night	Must be on the approved rota in PeopleHub.
Standby, Saturday, Sunday or bank holiday	£60 per day	Each calendar day counts separately.
Call-out worked	Paid overtime (G1 to G3) or TOIL (G4 and G5), minimum 1 hour per call-out	Call-out time must be logged in TimeTrack against the incident reference.

After a call-out that ends after 01:00, the employee may start the next working day up to 4 hours later without loss of pay so that the 11-hour rest period can be respected where practicable.

5.7 Shift arrangements

Customer support teams operating extended hours work rostered shifts published at least **2 weeks** in advance. Shift swaps must be approved by the team lead and recorded in PeopleHub. Shift patterns are part of the contract for roles advertised as shift-based.

5.8 Customer-site working

When working at a customer site, employees follow the customer's site rules (including working hours and security procedures) in addition to Northstar policies. Where customer rules conflict with Northstar's minimum standards on health and safety, information security or respectful conduct, the employee must raise the matter with their line manager. Travel to a customer site that is not the employee's normal workplace is business travel and is covered by section 12.

5.9 Alternative schedules

Approved alternative schedules (for example, a compressed 4-day week of 37.5 hours or a 9-day fortnight) are agreed through the flexible working procedure in section 10.6. On a compressed schedule, leave is calculated in hours, not days (see section 6.3).

6 Annual leave and public holidays

This section summarises the annual leave rules that apply from 1 October 2026. The authoritative detailed procedure, including additional worked examples, is in the Leave and Absence Standard NDS-HR-LAS-002 v1.2, section 3.

6.1 Annual leave entitlement

Table 6.1 — Annual leave entitlement for full-time employees (37.5 hours per week, 5 days per week)

Continuous service completed	Annual leave (days)	Bank holidays (days)	Total paid days off per leave year
Less than 3 years	27	8	35
3 years or more, but less than 5 years	28	8	36
5 years or more	29	8	37

- One day of annual leave equals **7.5 hours** for a full-time employee.
- The service-related increase applies from the **first 1 January that falls after** the date on which the employee completes the required continuous service. It is not applied part-way through a leave year.
- The entitlement applies to permanent and fixed-term employees, apprentices and interns. Part-time employees receive a pro-rated entitlement calculated in hours (section 6.3).
- Contractors and agency workers do not receive Northstar annual leave; agency workers' holiday is provided through their agency.

> **Statutory minimum holiday**
> Almost all workers are legally entitled to 5.6 weeks' paid holiday per year, capped at 28 days for someone working 5 or more days a week. Employers may include bank holidays within the 5.6 weeks. Northstar's entitlement of 27 days plus 8 bank holidays (35 days for a full-time employee) exceeds the statutory minimum. No pro-rating or rounding rule in this handbook will ever reduce an employee's entitlement below the statutory minimum.

6.2 Leave year and accrual

- The leave year runs from **1 January to 31 December**.
- Leave accrues evenly through the leave year at one-twelfth of the annual entitlement per complete calendar month of service. However, employees who have completed probation may book their full annual entitlement for the leave year in advance, subject to approval.
- Employees in probation may book only accrued leave plus a limited advance (section 6.16).
- Leave continues to accrue during sickness absence, family-related leave and other periods of paid leave. Leave does not accrue during unpaid sabbaticals or unpaid personal leave of more than 10 working days (section 9.7 and section 9.8).

6.3 Part-time employees and changes to working hours

Part-time employees' entitlement is calculated in hours and includes the bank holiday element, so that part-time employees are treated no less favourably than full-time employees, whichever days they work.

> **Part-time entitlement formula**
>
> Total annual allowance (hours) = 262.5 hours x (contracted weekly hours / 37.5)
>
> 262.5 hours is the full-time total of 35 days (27 annual leave days + 8 bank holidays) x 7.5 hours. For employees with 3 or more years' service the full-time total is 270 hours (36 days); with 5 or more years it is 277.5 hours (37 days).
>
> Bank holidays that fall on the employee's normal working days are deducted from the allowance, at the hours the employee would normally have worked that day. The remainder is available to book as annual leave.
>
> Rounding: round the total annual allowance up to the nearest 0.25 hour.

Table 6.3 — Part-time allowance examples, 2027 leave year, less than 3 years' service

Working pattern	FTE	Total allowance (hours)	Bank holidays on working days in 2027 (hours deducted)	Bookable annual leave (hours)
3 days, Mon–Wed, 7.5 hours per day (22.5 hours per week)	0.6	157.5	6 days x 7.5 = 45.0	112.5
4 days, Mon–Thu, 7.5 hours per day (30 hours per week)	0.8	210.0	6 days x 7.5 = 45.0	165.0
5 days, Mon–Fri, 6 hours per day (30 hours per week)	0.8	210.0	8 days x 6 = 48.0	162.0

In 2027 the bank holidays in England and Wales fall on Friday 1 January, Friday 26 March, Monday 29 March, Monday 3 May, Monday 31 May, Monday 30 August, Monday 27 December and Tuesday 28 December. An employee working Monday to Wednesday therefore has 6 bank holidays on working days (29 March, 3 May, 31 May, 30 August, 27 December and 28 December).

Changes to working hours part-way through the leave year. Where contracted hours change during the leave year, divide the leave year into periods at the date of change. Calculate the allowance for each period as: (annual allowance in hours for that working pattern) x (calendar days in the period / days in the leave year). Add the unrounded results together and then round the total up to the nearest 0.25 hour. Deduct bank holidays that fell on working days in each period at the hours worked on that day in that period. Leave already taken in the first period is deducted from the new total. Worked examples are in NDS-HR-LAS-002 section 3.4.

Compressed hours employees (for example, 37.5 hours worked over 4 days) are 1.0 FTE and receive 262.5 hours, with each bank holiday on a working day deducted at the length of that working day (9.375 hours on a 4-day compressed week).

6.4 Joining or leaving during the leave year

Joiner and leaver formula

Pro-rated annual leave = annual entitlement x (calendar days employed in the leave year / total days in the leave year)

Count calendar days inclusive of the start date and the leaving date. The leave year has 365 days (366 in a leap year; 2028 is the next leap year).

Rounding for full-time employees: round up to the nearest 0.5 day. Rounding for part-time employees (hours-based): round up to the nearest 0.25 hour.

Full-time joiners and leavers also receive, as paid days off, the bank holidays that fall during their employment. Part-time joiners and leavers use the hours-based allowance in section 6.3, pro-rated in the same way.

- **Joiner example:** a full-time employee starts on 1 March 2027. Calendar days employed in 2027 = 306 (1 March to 31 December inclusive). 27 x 306 / 365 = 22.64 days, rounded up to **23.0 days** of annual leave, plus the 7 bank holidays from 26 March 2027 onwards.
- **Leaver example:** a full-time employee with less than 3 years' service leaves on 30 June 2027. Calendar days employed in 2027 = 181. 27 x 181 / 365 = 13.39 days, rounded up to **13.5 days**.

6.5 Public and bank holidays [E&W]

Northstar observes the 8 bank holidays in England and Wales as paid days off in addition to annual leave. Employees based in Scotland or Northern Ireland observe their local bank holidays under a local schedule issued by People Operations.

Table 6.5 — Bank holidays in England and Wales, 2026 and 2027

Bank holiday	2026	2027
New Year's Day	Thursday 1 January	Friday 1 January
Good Friday	Friday 3 April	Friday 26 March
Easter Monday	Monday 6 April	Monday 29 March
Early May bank holiday	Monday 4 May	Monday 3 May
Spring bank holiday	Monday 25 May	Monday 31 May
Summer bank holiday	Monday 31 August	Monday 30 August
Christmas Day	Friday 25 December	Monday 27 December (substitute day)
Boxing Day	Monday 28 December (substitute day)	Tuesday 28 December (substitute day)

Employees who are required to work on a bank holiday (for example, on a support rota) receive the overtime or TOIL compensation in section 5.5 and a replacement day off to be taken within 3 months.

6.6 Requesting leave and minimum notice

All annual leave must be requested in PeopleHub and approved before it is taken. Leave is not approved until it shows as "Approved" in PeopleHub. Employees should not book non-refundable travel before approval.

Table 6.6 — Minimum notice for annual leave requests (requests submitted on or after 1 October 2026)

Length of leave requested	Minimum notice	Approver
Up to 1 working day (including hourly and half-day leave)	2 working days	Line manager
More than 1 and up to 5 working days	10 working days	Line manager
More than 5 and up to 10 working days	20 working days	Line manager
More than 10 and up to 15 consecutive working days	40 working days	Line manager and Head of Department
More than 15 consecutive working days	40 working days	Line manager, Head of Department and Director

How notice is counted. Notice is the number of working days between the date the request is submitted in PeopleHub and the first day of leave, counting neither the submission date nor the first day of leave. Bank holidays are not working days.

Managers may approve requests made with shorter notice at their discretion where cover allows. Short-notice approval is discretionary and is not an entitlement. Emergency situations are covered by section 9.2 (emergency leave and time off for dependants), not by annual leave rules.

6.7 Manager response, team coverage and critical delivery periods

- Managers must approve or decline a request in PeopleHub within **5 working days** of submission. If there is no decision after 5 working days, PeopleHub automatically escalates the request to the Head of Department. A request is not approved by default because a manager did not respond.
- Unless the Head of Department approves otherwise, no more than **30% of a team** (rounded down, with a minimum of one person) may be on planned annual leave on the same working day. For a team of 8 this is 2 people; for a team of 3 it is 1 person.
- A Head of Department may designate a **critical delivery period** (for example, a customer go-live, a data-centre migration or the Finance year-end close) by publishing it in PeopleHub at least **6 weeks** before it starts. A critical delivery period may last no more than **15 working days**, and no team may have more than **2** critical delivery periods in a leave year.
- Annual leave requested for dates within a published critical delivery period requires Head of Department approval in addition to line manager approval, and will normally be approved only in exceptional circumstances.
- Leave that was already approved before a critical delivery period was published remains approved. It can only be cancelled by the company under section 6.13.

6.8 Overlapping requests from colleagues

Where requests from colleagues would exceed the team coverage limit, the request submitted first in PeopleHub normally has priority. For high-demand periods (the 2 weeks around Christmas and New Year, and school summer holidays), managers may instead use a fair rotation based on who had leave in the same period in the previous year, provided this is explained to the team in advance. Managers must not decide between overlapping requests on the basis of a protected characteristic, and should consider requests linked to religious observance or caring responsibilities sympathetically.

6.9 Declined requests and escalation

A manager who declines a request must record the business reason in PeopleHub. The employee may ask the Head of Department to review the decision within **5 working days** of the decline. The Head of Department will respond within **5 working days** of receiving the review request, and their decision is final under this policy. This does not affect the employee's right to raise a grievance under section 15.6.

6.10 Half-day and hourly leave

- A half day of leave is 3.75 hours for a full-time employee, or half of the employee's normal working hours for that day.
- Hourly leave may be taken in whole-hour blocks with a minimum of 1 hour. Up to **37.5 hours** of an employee's annual leave allowance in each leave year may be taken as hourly leave (pro-rated for part-time employees). Hourly leave was introduced on 1 October 2026.
- Hourly and half-day leave count against the allowance in the same way as full days.

6.11 Carrying over unused leave

> **Standard carryover rule**
> Up to **5 days** (37.5 hours for a full-time employee; pro-rated for part-time employees by FTE) of unused annual leave may be carried over into the next leave year without approval. Carried-over leave must be taken by **31 March** of the next leave year. Carried-over leave not taken by 31 March is lost, unless one of the exceptions below applies.

Table 6.11 — Carryover exceptions

Situation	Rule	Approval and deadline
Employee could not take leave because of sickness absence	Untaken leave up to 4 weeks (20 days full-time, pro-rated) may be carried over, in addition to the standard 5 days.	Automatic on evidence of the sickness absence. Must be taken within 18 months of the end of the leave year in which it accrued.
Employee was on maternity, adoption, shared parental, neonatal care or other family-related leave	All untaken annual leave for the leave year is carried over.	Automatic. Must be taken within 12 months of the return-to-work date.
Exceptional business reasons (employee asked by the company to defer leave)	A further 5 days may be carried over (up to 10 days in total).	Request by 30 November in PeopleHub, approved by the Director of People Operations. Must be taken by 30 June of the next leave year.

Carryover beyond these limits is not available. An approved carryover exception is not a precedent for future years.

6.12 Sickness during annual leave

An employee who falls ill during annual leave may have the affected days reclassified as sickness absence and re-credited to their annual leave balance, provided that they:

1. report the sickness to their line manager by **09:30** on the first day of sickness (or as soon as reasonably practicable if they are in a different time zone), following section 7.1; and
2. provide self-certification for absences of up to 7 calendar days, or a fit note for absences of more than 7 calendar days, as set out in section 7.3.

Days of sickness reported only after the employee returns from leave will not normally be reclassified. Reclassified days are paid as sickness absence under section 7.

6.13 Cancelling approved leave

- **By the employee:** an employee may cancel approved leave in PeopleHub at least 2 working days before it starts. Later cancellation requires manager agreement.
- **By the company:** the company may cancel approved leave only in exceptional circumstances (for example, a Severity 1 incident or an unforeseen critical customer obligation). Cancellation must be approved by the Head of Department and, where possible, notified at least as many days in advance as the length of the leave being cancelled. The employee's leave is re-credited, and reasonable, evidenced non-refundable costs (for example, lost deposits and change fees) are reimbursed through ExpenseFlow with Director approval.

6.14 Company shutdown

Northstar closes its offices for 3 working days between Christmas and New Year. Employees must reserve **3 days** of annual leave for the shutdown (or the shutdown days that fall on their working days, for part-time employees). Shutdown dates are published by **31 January** each year.

Table 6.14 — Company shutdown dates

Leave year	Shutdown dates	Days to reserve (full-time)
2026	Tuesday 29, Wednesday 30 and Thursday 31 December 2026	3 days
2027	Wednesday 29, Thursday 30 and Friday 31 December 2027	3 days

Employees on the customer support or on-call rota during the shutdown work as rostered and take the equivalent leave at another time. New starters with insufficient leave may take unpaid leave for the shutdown or, with manager agreement, work remotely.

6.15 Transitional arrangements for the 2026 leave year

Version 2.0 of this handbook and the Leave and Absence Standard NDS-HR-LAS-002 v1.2 replaced the archived Leave Policy NDS-HR-LV-006 v1.0 on **1 October 2026**. The following transitional rules apply:

Table 6.15 — Transitional rules, 2026 leave year

Topic	Transitional rule
2026 annual leave entitlement (full-time, less than 5 years' service)	**25.5 days** plus bank holidays: 25 days under the archived policy plus an uplift of 0.5 day (the 2-day increase x 3/12, for October to December 2026).
2026 entitlement, part-time	The archived-policy allowance plus an uplift of 3.75 hours x FTE.
2026 service increments	Increments awarded under the archived policy (1 extra day after 5 years) continue for 2026. The new increments in Table 6.1 apply from 1 January 2027.
Notice for requests	Requests submitted before 1 October 2026 are assessed against the notice rules in force on the date of submission (the archived policy), even if the leave falls on or after 1 October 2026. Requests submitted on or after 1 October 2026 follow Table 6.6.
Carryover from 2025 into 2026	Governed by the archived policy (3 days, to be taken by 28 February 2026).
Carryover from 2026 into 2027	Governed by section 6.11 (5 days, to be taken by 31 March 2027).
Hourly leave	Available for leave dates from 1 October 2026.

6.16 Leave during probation, negative balances and leave during notice periods

Probation. During probation an employee may book leave that will have accrued by the first day of the leave (the annual entitlement x complete calendar months of service / 12, rounded up to the nearest 0.5 day) plus up to **2 additional days** with line manager approval. Leave of more than 5 consecutive working days during probation also requires Head of Department approval.

Negative balances. After probation, an employee may book their full annual entitlement in advance. With Head of Department approval, an employee may also borrow up to **3 days** from the next leave year in exceptional circumstances. If employment ends when an employee has taken more leave than they have accrued, the excess is deducted from final pay at the daily rate in section 6.17, where the employment contract contains a written deduction clause (all Northstar contracts issued on or after 1 January 2025 contain this clause) or the employee has given prior written consent.

Notice periods. Employees serving notice may request leave in the normal way. Northstar may require an employee to take some or all of their accrued but untaken leave during their notice period by giving notice of at least twice the length of the leave to be taken. Approved leave that falls after the employee's leaving date is cancelled automatically. During garden leave (section 22.6), Northstar may require accrued leave to be taken.

6.17 Termination and final holiday balance

Final holiday balance formula

Final balance (days) = pro-rated entitlement for the leave year up to the leaving date (section 6.4) + valid carried-over leave − leave taken or booked up to the leaving date

Daily rate for payment or deduction (full-time) = annual basic salary / 260

Hourly rate for payment or deduction (part-time and hours-based calculations) = annual basic salary / (52 x contracted weekly hours)

Example — positive balance. A full-time employee earning £45,500 per year leaves on 30 June 2027 with no carried-over leave and has taken 10 days. Pro-rated entitlement = 13.5 days (section 6.4). Balance = 13.5 − 10 = 3.5 days. Payment = 3.5 x (£45,500 / 260) = 3.5 x £175.00 = **£612.50** gross, paid in the final salary payment.

Example — negative balance. If the same employee had taken 15 days, the balance would be 13.5 − 15 = −1.5 days. Deduction = 1.5 x £175.00 = **£262.50** gross, deducted from final pay where the contract permits (section 6.16).

6.18 Holiday pay

Holiday pay is paid at the employee's normal basic pay. Where an employee regularly receives overtime, on-call allowances or commission, their holiday pay includes an average of those payments over the previous 52 weeks in which they were paid. This is a legal requirement for at least 4 weeks of statutory leave; Northstar applies the same average to all paid annual leave and bank holidays as a company enhancement. Payments in lieu of untaken leave are made only on termination of employment; untaken leave cannot otherwise be exchanged for pay.

7 Sickness absence and medical appointments

The authoritative detailed procedure is in the Leave and Absence Standard NDS-HR-LAS-002 v1.2, section 4.

7.1 Reporting an absence

How to report sickness

1. **Call** your line manager (telephone or Teams voice/video call) no later than **09:30** on the first day of absence. Shift workers and employees on an on-call rota must call at least **1 hour before** their shift or rota period starts. 2. If your line manager is unavailable, call your Head of Department or team lead. Leaving a voicemail is acceptable only if you also send a message and follow up with a call before 12:00. 3. Text messages, emails or chat messages alone are not sufficient, except where you are physically unable to speak; in that case, send a message and call as soon as you are able. 4. Record the absence in PeopleHub on the same day, or ask your manager to do so on your behalf. 5. Tell your manager the reason for absence in general terms, your expected return date, and any work that needs urgent cover. You do not have to disclose a diagnosis.

7.2 Keeping in touch during absence

Employees must update their line manager on the **third working day** of absence and then at least **weekly**, unless a different arrangement is agreed. The line manager is responsible for maintaining supportive, proportionate contact; for long-term absence, contact should be at least every 2 weeks and agreed with the employee.

7.3 Self-certification and medical evidence

Table 7.3 — Evidence required for sickness absence

Length of absence (calendar days, including non-working days)	Evidence required
1 to 7 calendar days	Self-certification form in PeopleHub, completed on the day of return.
More than 7 calendar days	A fit note from a doctor or another healthcare professional who is permitted to issue fit notes, covering the period from day 8 onwards, submitted within 3 working days of being issued. Further fit notes must be provided before the previous one expires.
Repeated short-term absence (Stage 1 or above under section 7.6)	Northstar may request a fit note for any further absence. Northstar will reimburse any charge for obtaining it.

Fit notes

Employees must give their employer a fit note if they are off work for more than 7 days in a row, including non-working days. A fit note may state that the employee is "not fit for work" or "may be fit for work" with adjustments such as a phased return, altered hours, amended duties or workplace adaptations. Where a fit note says "may be fit for work", the line manager discusses whether the suggested adjustments can be accommodated.

7.4 Statutory Sick Pay (SSP)

Statutory Sick Pay from 6 April 2026

Following the Employment Rights Act 2025, from 6 April 2026 SSP is payable from the first day of sickness absence (the former 3 unpaid "waiting days" were removed) and the lower earnings limit no longer applies to eligibility. The weekly rate is £123.25 or 80% of the employee's normal weekly earnings, whichever is lower, for up to 28 weeks. Northstar's qualifying days for SSP are the employee's contracted working days. SSP rates are set by government and usually change each April.

7.5 Company sick pay

Company sick pay is a contractual enhancement for employees whose contract incorporates the company sick pay scheme (all permanent and fixed-term employment contracts issued from 1 January 2025). It is paid **inclusive of SSP**: SSP forms part of, and is not paid in addition to, company sick pay.

Table 7.5 — Company sick pay entitlement in any rolling 12-month period

Continuous service on the first day of absence	Full pay	Then half pay
During probation	SSP only	SSP only
Probation completed and less than 2 years	4 weeks	4 weeks
2 years or more but less than 5 years	8 weeks	8 weeks
5 years or more	13 weeks	13 weeks

- The rolling 12-month period is the 12 months ending on the day before the first day of the current absence. Company sick pay already paid in that period is deducted from the entitlement.
- "Half pay" is half of basic pay; where half pay would be less than SSP, SSP is paid instead. After company sick pay is exhausted, SSP continues if the statutory conditions are met.
- Weeks are calculated by reference to the employee's normal working days (for example, one week for a 3-day-per-week employee is 3 working days).
- Company sick pay is conditional on following the reporting procedure in section 7.1 and providing the evidence in section 7.3. If the employee does not follow these steps without a good reason, company sick pay may be withheld for the affected days. Statutory Sick Pay is still paid where the statutory conditions are met.
- Contractors and agency workers are not eligible for company sick pay.

Example. An employee with 3 years' continuous service has received 5 weeks of full company sick pay in the previous 12 months. They are now absent for 6 weeks. Remaining full-pay entitlement = 8 − 5 = 3 weeks. They

therefore receive 3 weeks at full pay followed by 3 weeks at half pay (they have 8 weeks of half-pay entitlement available).

7.6 Repeated short-term absence

Table 7.6 — Attendance review stages

Stage	Trigger (rolling 12 months)	Action
Stage 0 — supportive review	3 or more separate absences, or 8 or more working days of absence	Informal supportive meeting with the line manager to understand causes and agree support. No warning is given.
Stage 1 — first attendance review	Further absence within 6 months after a Stage 0 review that meets the trigger again	Formal meeting with People Operations. Possible first written improvement notice, valid for 6 months. Occupational Health referral considered.
Stage 2 — final attendance review	Further absence within the validity of a Stage 1 notice	Formal meeting. Possible final improvement notice, valid for 12 months.
Stage 3 — capability hearing	Further absence within the validity of a Stage 2 notice	Hearing chaired by a Head of Department. Outcomes may include redeployment or dismissal on notice on capability grounds.

Triggers are a prompt for a conversation, not an automatic sanction. Pregnancy-related absence is excluded from all triggers. Disability-related absence is recorded separately and managers must consider reasonable adjustments, including adjusting the triggers, with advice from People Operations and Occupational Health.

7.7 Long-term sickness absence and Occupational Health

An absence of **4 consecutive weeks** or more is long-term. The line manager will normally make an Occupational Health (OH) referral at this point, or earlier if the employee's circumstances suggest it would help. The employee is told the reasons for the referral and sees the questions asked; OH reports are shared with the manager only with the employee's consent and normally address fitness for work and adjustments rather than diagnosis. Long-term absence that is unlikely to end within a reasonable time may lead to a capability review under section 15.

7.8 Return-to-work meetings and phased returns

- A return-to-work conversation takes place within **2 working days** of the employee's return after any sickness absence. For an absence of 1 or 2 days this can be a brief check-in.
- A **phased return** (reduced hours or duties) of up to **4 weeks** at full pay may be agreed where recommended by a fit note or OH. A longer phased return requires Head of Department approval; after 4 weeks the employee is paid for hours worked and may use annual leave or remaining company sick pay for the balance.

7.9 Disability, pregnancy and mental health

- **Disability-related absence:** handled with reasonable adjustments (section 4.3). Absence connected with an agreed adjustment (for example, scheduled treatment) may be recorded as disability leave rather than sickness absence.
- **Pregnancy-related sickness:** recorded separately and never counted towards attendance triggers or used in decisions about performance, promotion or redundancy. If a pregnant employee is absent with a pregnancy-related illness in the 4 weeks before the expected week of childbirth, maternity leave and pay may start automatically (see section 8.1).
- **Mental health:** treated in the same way as physical illness. Employees can access the Employee Assistance Programme (Appendix B) and agree a Wellness Action Plan with their manager.

7.10 Medical and dental appointments

Employees should arrange routine medical, dental and optical appointments outside core hours where possible, using flexible start and finish times. Where this is not possible, up to **2 hours** of paid time per appointment is allowed with line manager approval. If an employee needs more than **4** appointments in a rolling 3-month period, the manager should discuss support needs with them and People Operations. Time off for hospital treatment, disability-related appointments and pregnancy-related appointments is covered by section 7.9, section 8.9 and section 9.5.

7.11 Suspected misuse of absence procedures

Concerns that sickness absence is not genuine (for example, social media posts suggesting the employee is on holiday, or a repeated pattern of absence on Mondays) must be raised with People Operations. Managers must not make accusations or contact the employee's doctor. Concerns are investigated fairly under the disciplinary procedure (section 15), and an employee will always have the opportunity to explain before any conclusion is reached.

7.12 Privacy and medical information

Health information is special category personal data under UK data protection law. Fit notes, OH reports and medical details are stored in the restricted health area of PeopleHub, which only People Operations case owners can access. Managers see absence dates, expected return dates and recommended adjustments, not diagnoses, unless the employee chooses to share more. Health information must never be shared in team channels or entered into any generative AI tool (see section 19).

8 Family-related leave

This section summarises family-related leave and pay. Statutory figures are those published on GOV.UK for the 2026/27 tax year (see the References section) and usually change each April. Eligibility for statutory leave and statutory pay is assessed separately: an employee can be entitled to leave but not to statutory pay. The authoritative detailed procedure is in NDS-HR-LAS-002 section 5.

> **Not everyone qualifies for every type of leave or pay**
> Most family leave is a day-one right for employees, but statutory pay usually depends on continuous service and average earnings, and company enhancements have their own conditions. Contractors and agency workers are not employees and are not entitled to these employee leave rights through Northstar. Always check the eligibility conditions in the relevant row of Table 8.0.

Table 8.0 — Family leave and pay at a glance (as at 1 October 2026)

Leave type	Leave eligibility	Statutory pay and its eligibility	Northstar enhancement
Maternity	Employees, from day one	SMP: 39 weeks; 90% of average weekly earnings (AWE) for 6 weeks, then £194.32 or 90% of AWE (whichever is lower) for 33 weeks. Requires 26 weeks' continuous service into the 15th week before the expected week of childbirth (EWC) and AWE of at least £129.	Enhanced maternity pay (section 8.1).
Paternity	Employees, from day one (since 6 April 2026)	SPP: up to 2 weeks at £194.32 or 90% of AWE (whichever is lower). Requires 26 weeks' continuous service by the end of the 15th week before the EWC, employment up to the birth, and AWE of at least £129.	Full pay for 2 weeks if eligible for SPP (section 8.2).
Adoption	Employees, from day one	SAP: 39 weeks, paid on the same basis as SMP. Requires 26 weeks' continuous service by the week of matching and AWE of at least £129.	Enhanced adoption pay, same as maternity (section 8.3).
Shared parental	Employees who meet the continuity test and whose partner meets the employment and earnings test	ShPP: £194.32 or 90% of AWE (whichever is lower). Up to 50 weeks' leave and 37 weeks' pay shared between parents.	None. ShPP only.
Unpaid parental	Employees with parental responsibility, from day one (since 6 April 2026)	Unpaid	None.
Neonatal care	Employees, from day one	Statutory Neonatal Care Pay: £194.32 or 90% of AWE (whichever is lower). Requires 26 weeks' continuous service and minimum earnings.	Top-up to full pay with 26 weeks' service (section 8.6).
Time off for dependants	Employees, from day one	Unpaid	Up to 2 paid days per occurrence, maximum 5 paid days per leave year (section 8.8).
Carer's leave	Employees, from day one	Unpaid	First 3 days paid in any rolling 12 months (section 8.8).

8.1 Maternity leave and pay

Leave. Pregnant employees are entitled to up to 52 weeks of Statutory Maternity Leave (26 weeks of Ordinary Maternity Leave and 26 weeks of Additional Maternity Leave), regardless of length of service, hours or pay. The earliest leave can start is 11 weeks before the EWC. Employees must take at least 2 weeks of compulsory maternity leave after the birth.

Notice. By the end of the 15th week before the EWC, the employee must tell People Operations (via PeopleHub) that she is pregnant, her EWC and the date she wants maternity leave to start. Northstar will confirm the expected return date in writing within 28 days. To change the return date, the employee must give at least 8 weeks' notice.

Statutory Maternity Pay. SMP requires at least 28 days' notice of the date SMP should start and evidence of pregnancy (a MATB1 certificate or a letter from a doctor or midwife) within 21 days of the SMP start date. A MATB1 cannot be issued more than 20 weeks before the due date. Employees who do not qualify for SMP may be able to claim Maternity Allowance from the government; Northstar will issue form SMP1 explaining why SMP is not payable.

Northstar enhanced maternity pay. Employees who qualify for SMP **and** have at least 26 weeks' continuous service at the end of the 15th week before the EWC receive:

Table 8.1 — Northstar enhanced maternity and adoption pay

Weeks of leave	Payment
Weeks 1 to 16	Full basic pay, inclusive of SMP or SAP.
Weeks 17 to 39	SMP or SAP only.
Weeks 40 to 52	Unpaid.

If the employee does not return to work for at least **6 months** after the end of maternity leave, she must repay the enhanced element (the amount paid above SMP), unless employment ends because of redundancy, ill-health capability, or a further period of statutory family leave immediately following the first. Statutory pay is never repayable because an employee does not return.

8.2 Paternity leave and pay

Leave. Since 6 April 2026, paternity leave is a day-one right for eligible employees. An employee who is the biological father of the child, or the partner of the mother or adopter, and who expects to have responsibility for the child's upbringing, may take up to **2 weeks** of paternity leave, as one 2-week block or two separate 1-week blocks. Leave cannot start before the birth and must end within 52 weeks of the birth (or of the due date if the baby is born early).

Notice. The employee must tell People Operations the due date at least 15 weeks before the baby is due, and must give 28 days' notice to change the start date of paternity leave.

Statutory Paternity Pay. SPP is £194.32 per week or 90% of AWE, whichever is lower. It requires at least 26 weeks' continuous service by the end of the qualifying week (the 15th week before the EWC), continued employment up to the date of birth, and AWE of at least £129.

Northstar enhancement. Employees who qualify for SPP receive **full basic pay for 2 weeks**, inclusive of SPP. Employees who are entitled to paternity leave but do not qualify for SPP (for example, because they joined less than 26 weeks before the qualifying week) take paternity leave unpaid; they may choose to use annual leave instead for some or all of the period.

8.3 Adoption leave and pay

Employees who are adopting (or who are intended parents in an eligible surrogacy arrangement) can take up to 52 weeks of Statutory Adoption Leave from day one of employment, provided they give the correct notice and supply proof of the adoption or surrogacy if requested. Statutory Adoption Pay requires at least 26 weeks' continuous employment by the week the employee was matched with a child and AWE of at least £129. Northstar enhanced adoption pay follows Table 8.1 on the same conditions as enhanced maternity pay, measured at the week of matching. The adopter's partner may be entitled to paternity leave (section 8.2).

8.4 Shared parental leave and pay

Eligible parents can share up to **50 weeks** of leave and up to **37 weeks** of pay by ending maternity or adoption leave early. Eligibility depends on both parents: the employee must meet the continuity of employment test (normally 26 weeks' continuous service by the end of the 15th week before the EWC or by the week of matching, and still employed in the first week of shared parental leave), and the other parent must meet the employment and earnings test. The employee must give at least **8 weeks' written notice** of leave dates. Requests for discontinuous blocks may be refused; the employee may then take the leave as one continuous block. Northstar pays ShPP only; there is no company enhancement for shared parental pay.

8.5 Unpaid parental leave

Since 6 April 2026, unpaid parental leave is a day-one right for eligible employees. Employees with parental responsibility may take up to **18 weeks** of unpaid parental leave for each child up to the child's 18th birthday, with a maximum of **4 weeks per child in any year**. Leave must be taken in whole weeks unless the child is disabled or Northstar agrees otherwise, and the employee must give **21 days' notice** of the start and end dates. Northstar may postpone leave for up to 6 months where the business would be unduly disrupted, except where leave is requested to start immediately after a birth or adoption; any postponement is confirmed in writing within 7 days of the request with the new dates. Northstar may ask for reasonable proof of parental responsibility but will not ask for it each time leave is requested.

8.6 Neonatal care leave and pay

Parents whose baby is admitted to neonatal care within 28 days of birth and stays in care for at least 7 full, consecutive days can take up to **12 weeks** of neonatal care leave (one week for each full week the baby spends in neonatal care). Leave is a day-one right and must be taken within 68 weeks of the birth. Statutory Neonatal Care Pay requires at least 26 weeks' continuous service and minimum earnings. Northstar tops up Statutory Neonatal Care Pay to **full basic pay** for employees with at least 26 weeks' continuous service. Neonatal care leave is taken in addition to other family leave.

8.7 Pregnancy and adoption appointments

- Pregnant employees have a statutory right to reasonable **paid** time off for antenatal care, including relaxation and parenting classes recommended by a doctor or midwife. After the first appointment, Northstar may ask to see an appointment card and confirmation of pregnancy.
- Partners of a pregnant woman have a statutory right to unpaid time off to accompany her to up to two antenatal appointments, of up to 6.5 hours each. Northstar pays this time in full as a company enhancement.
- Employees adopting a child can take time off for adoption appointments in line with the statutory scheme; Northstar pays this time in full.

8.8 Time off for dependants, emergency leave and carer's leave

Time off for dependants (statutory). All employees may take a reasonable amount of time off to deal with an emergency involving a dependant — for example, a child falling ill, a breakdown in care arrangements, or a dependant being involved in an incident. A dependant can be a spouse, partner, child, grandchild, parent, or someone who depends on the employee for care. The right covers unexpected situations, not events the employee knew about in advance. There is no fixed limit; "reasonable" usually means enough time to deal with the immediate emergency and arrange alternative care. Statutory time off for dependants is unpaid.

Northstar enhancement. Northstar pays up to **2 working days per occurrence**, up to a maximum of **5 paid days per leave year**. Further time is unpaid, or the employee may choose to use annual leave.

Carer's leave (statutory). Employees can take up to **one week** of unpaid carer's leave in any 12-month period to give or arrange care for a dependant with a long-term care need. It is available from the first day of employment and can be taken in half days, individual days or a whole week. Notice must be at least 3 days for a half day or a full day, and at least twice the length of the leave for more than one day. No evidence of the dependant's care needs is required. **Northstar enhancement:** the first **3 days** of carer's leave in any rolling 12 months are paid at full basic pay.

8.9 Keeping-in-touch days

By agreement, an employee on maternity or adoption leave may work up to **10 keeping-in-touch (KIT) days**, and an employee on shared parental leave may work up to **20 shared parental leave in touch (SPLIT) days**, without ending their leave. KIT and SPLIT days are optional for both parties. Northstar pays KIT and SPLIT days at the employee's normal daily rate, inclusive of any statutory pay due for that day.

8.10 Flexible working linked to caring responsibilities

Employees returning from family leave, or with caring responsibilities, may request flexible working under the statutory procedure in section 10.6. Requests are considered on their merits; caring responsibilities are a relevant factor in the manager's decision but do not create an automatic right to a particular pattern.

8.11 Returning to work

- After Ordinary Maternity or Adoption Leave (the first 26 weeks), the employee is entitled to return to the same job on the same terms.
- After Additional Maternity or Adoption Leave, the employee is entitled to return to the same job or, if that is not reasonably practicable, a suitable alternative job on terms no less favourable.
- Employees who are pregnant, on maternity, adoption or shared parental leave, or have recently returned from it, have additional legal protection in a redundancy situation and must be offered any suitable alternative vacancy in priority to other employees during the protected period.
- Annual leave continues to accrue during family leave and may be carried over under section 6.11.
- A return-to-work meeting will be held in the first week back to agree any phased return, flexible working request or support needed.

9 Other forms of leave

Table 9.0 shows the status of each type of leave in this section. "Statutory" means a legal right; "Company" means a Northstar enhancement; "Discretionary" means the request may be refused and is never automatic.

Table 9.0 — Status of other forms of leave

Leave type	Status	Paid?	Approver
Compassionate and bereavement leave	Company (statutory for parental bereavement)	Yes, up to limits	Line manager
Parental bereavement leave	Statutory, with company pay enhancement	Yes (company full pay for 2 weeks)	Line manager (notification)
Jury service	Statutory time off; pay is company	First 10 working days	Line manager (notification)
Public duties	Statutory reasonable time off; pay is company	Up to 5 days per leave year	Line manager
Unpaid personal leave	Discretionary	No	Head of Department
Sabbatical or career break	Discretionary	No	Director
Study and examination leave	Company, for sponsored qualifications	Yes, up to 5 days per leave year	Line manager
Religious observance	Request considered under annual leave or flexible working	Annual leave or unpaid	Line manager
Reservist training	Company	Up to 10 days per leave year	Line manager
Volunteering	Company (discretionary approval of the activity)	Up to 2 days per leave year	Line manager

9.1 Compassionate and bereavement leave

Table 9.1 — Compassionate and bereavement leave

Circumstance	Paid leave	Notes
Death of a spouse, civil partner, partner, child, parent, sibling, grandparent, grandchild, parent-in-law, or a person for whom the employee was the main carer	Up to 5 working days per bereavement	Company provision. Need not be taken consecutively; must be taken within 3 months of the death.
Death of a child under 18, or stillbirth after 24 weeks of pregnancy	Statutory Parental Bereavement Leave of up to 2 weeks, paid by Northstar at full basic pay	Statutory leave is a day-one right and must be taken within 56 weeks of the death or stillbirth. Northstar pays full basic pay for both weeks regardless of service (company enhancement; Statutory Parental Bereavement Pay is included).
Pregnancy loss before 24 weeks (employee or partner)	Up to 5 working days	Company provision. At the date of this handbook, a statutory entitlement to bereavement leave for pregnancy loss under the Employment Rights Act 2025 had not yet commenced.
Death of another relative or close friend	1 working day to attend the funeral	Company provision.
Serious illness of an immediate family member	Up to 2 working days	Company provision, at manager discretion; further time may be taken as carer's leave, time off for dependants or annual leave.

Further time off may be agreed as annual leave or unpaid leave. Evidence is not normally requested. Managers should respond with flexibility and sensitivity, including to cultural and religious practices around mourning.

9.2 Emergency leave

Genuine emergencies involving a dependant are handled as time off for dependants (section 8.8). Other emergencies (for example, a flood or break-in at home) may be covered by up to 1 day of paid emergency leave at the line manager's discretion, after which annual leave or unpaid leave is used. Emergency leave is reported by calling the line manager as soon as possible, using the same steps as section 7.1.

9.3 Jury service

Northstar must allow employees time off for jury service. Employees must tell their line manager and upload a copy of the summons to PeopleHub within **2 working days** of receiving it. If the absence would seriously harm the business, Northstar may ask the employee to apply to defer jury service, giving the employee a letter explaining why; jury service can be deferred only once in a 12-month period. Northstar pays full basic pay for the first **10 working days** of jury service in any leave year; the employee must not claim loss of earnings from the court for those days. After 10 working days, jury service is unpaid by Northstar and the employee may claim loss of earnings from the court using the court's employer form, which People Operations will complete.

9.4 Public duties

Employees who hold certain public positions (for example, magistrate, local councillor, school governor, or member of a statutory tribunal) have a statutory right to a reasonable amount of time off to perform their duties. The statutory right is to unpaid time off. Northstar pays up to **5 working days** per leave year; further time is unpaid. Employees must agree the amount of time with their line manager in advance.

9.5 Medical and dental appointments

See section 7.10.

9.6 Unpaid personal leave

Unpaid personal leave of up to **10 working days** per leave year may be approved at the Head of Department's discretion, normally only once the employee's annual leave for the year has been used or booked. It is not an entitlement. Requests of more than 10 working days are considered as sabbaticals (section 9.7).

9.7 Sabbaticals and career breaks

Employees who will have at least **5 years' continuous service** on the proposed start date may apply for an unpaid sabbatical of **1 to 3 months**, no more than once in any 5-year period. Applications must be made at least **3 months** before the proposed start and approved by a Director. Approval is discretionary and depends on business needs. During a sabbatical, employment continues, but salary, pension contributions and annual leave accrual are suspended for the unpaid period; life assurance and private medical insurance continue.

9.8 Study and examination leave

Employees taking a qualification sponsored by Northstar (for example, a cloud certification or professional accountancy qualification) may take up to **5 days** of paid study and examination leave per leave year in total, consisting of the exam day itself and up to 1 study day per exam. Apprentices receive off-the-job training time as required by their apprenticeship programme rules; this is working time, not leave. Learning budgets are covered in section 13.6.

9.9 Religious observance

Northstar recognises that employees may need time away from work for religious festivals or observance. Requests are made as annual leave under section 6.6 or, where appropriate, as a short flexible-working change (for example, an earlier finish during a period of fasting). Managers must consider requests fairly and may decline only for a genuine business reason. Time off for religious observance is not additional paid leave.

9.10 Reservist duties

Members of the UK Reserve Forces receive up to **10 working days** of paid leave per leave year for annual training, in addition to annual leave, as a company enhancement. If a reservist is mobilised, their employment is protected under the Reserve Forces (Safeguard of Employment) Act 1985. Employees must tell their line manager as soon as they receive notice of training or mobilisation.

9.11 Volunteering

Employees may take up to **2 paid days** per leave year to volunteer with a registered charity or community organisation, once their line manager has approved the activity and the dates.

9.12 Other legally protected time off

Employees have statutory rights to time off in other circumstances, including for trade union duties and activities, as an employee or health and safety representative, as a pension scheme trustee, and to look for work or arrange training when under notice of redundancy (employees with at least 2 years' service). Contact People Operations before declining any request in these categories.

10 Hybrid, remote and flexible working

This section summarises Northstar's approach. The authoritative detailed rules are in the Hybrid and Flexible Working Standard NDS-HR-HFW-005 v1.1.

10.1 Three different arrangements

Table 10.1 — Hybrid working, flexible working and work-location changes

Feature	Hybrid working arrangement	Formal flexible-working request	Contractual work-location change
What it is	The team-level pattern of office and home working for roles designated as hybrid	A statutory application to change hours, times, days or place of work	A permanent change of contractual workplace, such as a move to a remote contract or a different office
Contractual?	No — it can be adjusted under section 10.9	Yes, once approved (unless agreed as a trial or temporary change)	Yes
How to request	Agree with line manager within the team pattern	Written statutory application in PeopleHub	Flexible-working application or role change approved by HoD and People Operations
Decision timescale	Line manager discretion	Within 2 months of the request, including any appeal	Within 2 months if made as a statutory request

10.2 Attendance expectations

Employees in roles designated as hybrid are expected to attend a Northstar office or a customer site for at least **8 days in each rolling 4-week period** (equivalent to 2 days per week). Teams set **anchor days** on which most of the team attends together. Attendance is measured using access-card data and PeopleHub location status, and is reviewed by line managers in 1:1s, not used automatically as a disciplinary measure. Employees with a remote contract, an agreed reasonable adjustment or an approved flexible-working arrangement follow their individual arrangement instead.

10.3 Working hours, availability and communication

Hybrid and remote employees work their normal contracted hours, are available during core hours (section 5.1), keep their Teams status and PeopleHub location up to date, and respond to messages within a reasonable time during working hours. Cameras are expected for customer meetings unless an adjustment applies, and are optional for internal meetings.

10.4 Home-working equipment

Northstar provides a laptop, one external monitor, a keyboard, a mouse and a headset to hybrid and remote employees. After completing probation, employees may claim a **home office allowance of up to £300** (including VAT), once in any 3-year period, for a desk, chair or other ergonomic equipment, with receipts, through ExpenseFlow. Equipment provided as a reasonable adjustment is funded separately and does not count towards the allowance.

10.5 Health, safety, ergonomics, confidentiality and secure connections

- Complete the display screen equipment (DSE) self-assessment in PeopleHub within **2 weeks** of starting home working, and again if your set-up changes.
- Report any accident or injury while working at home in the same way as in the office (section 17.3).
- Position screens so that others in a shared home or public place cannot see Confidential or Restricted information; lock your screen whenever you step away; use a headset for calls involving Confidential information.

- Always connect through Northstar Secure Connect (VPN) when not on a Northstar office network. Public Wi-Fi may be used for Public and Internal information only when Northstar Secure Connect is active. Restricted information must not be accessed on public Wi-Fi or in public places at all (see section 19).

10.6 Formal flexible-working requests

All employees can make a statutory flexible-working request from their first day of employment, and can make up to **2 statutory requests in any 12-month period**. A request can cover hours, start and finish times, working days, or place of work.

> **Flexible working — process and deadlines**
> 1. Submit a written request in PeopleHub stating that it is a statutory request for flexible working, the date of the request, the working pattern requested and the proposed start date, and whether and when any earlier request was made. 2. The line manager acknowledges the request within **5 working days**. 3. The line manager meets the employee to discuss the request within **4 weeks** of receiving it. A request cannot be refused without first consulting the employee. 4. A written decision is issued, and any appeal concluded, within **2 months** of the date of the request, unless the employee agrees to an extension. 5. A refusal must give one or more of the statutory business reasons and explain why it applies. 6. The employee may appeal within **10 working days** of the decision. The appeal is heard by a different, more senior manager.

The statutory business reasons for refusing a request are: the burden of additional costs; inability to reorganise work among existing staff; inability to recruit additional staff; a detrimental effect on quality; a detrimental effect on performance; a detrimental effect on ability to meet customer demand; insufficient work during the periods the employee proposes to work; and planned structural changes. Managers may agree a **trial period of up to 3 months** before confirming a permanent change.

10.7 Temporary arrangements

A line manager may agree a temporary change to working pattern or location for up to **6 months** (for example, during a house move, a period of caring responsibilities or a phased return). Temporary arrangements are recorded in PeopleHub with an end date, are not contractual, and end automatically on the recorded date unless extended in writing. A temporary arrangement may reduce office attendance below the 8-day standard for no more than 4 weeks; a longer reduction is an attendance exception under section 23.1.

10.8 Working overseas and cross-border working

Working from outside the UK raises tax, social security, immigration, insurance, employment-law and data-protection risks for both the employee and Northstar.

- Employees who have completed probation and are not serving notice may work temporarily from another country for up to **10 working days** in any rolling 12-month period, only with prior approval through the "Work From Abroad" request in PeopleHub, submitted at least **4 weeks** before travel and approved by the line manager, People Operations and IT Security.
- Work from abroad is not permitted from countries on the IT Security restricted-destination list, and Restricted information must not be accessed from outside the UK unless the CISO has approved it in writing and the customer contract permits it.
- Requests for more than 10 working days are exceptions that require Director of People Operations approval and external tax and immigration advice; no exception may exceed 20 working days in a rolling 12-month period.
- Working while on holiday abroad without approval (for example, checking email for a few minutes is acceptable, but joining customer calls or accessing customer systems is not) is a breach of this policy.

Full rules and examples are in NDS-HR-HFW-005 section 7.

10.9 Changing or ending arrangements

Northstar may change a team's hybrid pattern or anchor days for genuine business reasons by giving at least **4 weeks' notice**, or less in an emergency. A contractual flexible-working arrangement can be changed only by agreement, by a further statutory request, or through a proper consultation process. An employee may ask to return to their previous pattern; this is treated as a new request.

10.10 Accessibility and caring responsibilities

Hybrid and flexible arrangements are a common reasonable adjustment for disabled employees and a frequent request from carers. Where a request is linked to a disability, the manager must consider the duty to make reasonable adjustments (section 4.3) in addition to the flexible-working procedure. Adjustments are not limited by the 2-requests-per-year statutory limit.

10.11 Manager decision criteria and examples

Managers assess requests using objective criteria: the requirements of the role (for example, hands-on hardware work or customer-site obligations), team coverage, customer commitments, the employee's ability to work securely, any reasonable-adjustment duty, and the effect on colleagues. Managers must not decide on the basis of personal preference, presenteeism or assumptions about a person's circumstances.

- **Example 1:** A G2 engineer asks to work Monday to Thursday, 9.375 hours per day (compressed hours). The team's on-call rota can be rearranged and customer coverage is unaffected. The request is approved for a 3-month trial.
- **Example 2:** A service-desk analyst asks to work fully remotely. The role requires physical device handling at the Manchester office on 3 days a week. The manager consults the employee and offers 2 remote days per week instead; the full request is refused for "inability to reorganise work among existing staff", with an explanation.
- **Example 3:** An employee asks to change their start time to 07:30 to manage school drop-off. This falls within the flexible band in section 5.1 and core hours are unaffected, so no formal request is needed.

11 Pay, payroll, deductions and benefits

11.1 Salary payment

Salaries are paid monthly, for the calendar month, by bank transfer on the **25th of each month**. If the 25th falls on a weekend or bank holiday, salary is paid on the previous working day.

11.2 Payroll cut-off

The payroll cut-off is the **10th of each month**. Changes received and approved by the cut-off (new starters, leavers, bank-detail changes, overtime, approved expenses, allowances and unpaid leave) are processed in that month's payroll. Items received after the cut-off are processed in the following month's payroll. A new starter whose details are incomplete at the cut-off is paid in the next payroll; on request, People Operations may arrange an advance of net pay.

11.3 Payslips

Payslips are published in PeopleHub by the **23rd of each month**. Each payslip shows gross pay, deductions and net pay, as required by law.

11.4 Incorrect or missed payments

Report suspected pay errors to payroll@northstar.example within 5 working days of the payslip being published. An underpayment of **more than £100** caused by a Northstar error is corrected by an off-cycle payment within **3 working days** of confirmation; smaller underpayments are corrected in the next payroll.

11.5 Bank-detail changes

Bank details can be changed only by the employee through PeopleHub, followed by a verification call from Payroll to the phone number already held on file. Payroll will **never** act on a request to change bank details received by email, chat or phone. Requests to change bank details by email should be treated as a possible fraud and reported to security@northstar.example. Changes completed by the 10th apply to that month's salary.

11.6 Salary reviews

Salaries are reviewed annually, with any change normally effective from **1 April**. Salary review increases are discretionary and are not guaranteed, except where a contract or collective agreement provides otherwise or where an increase is needed to meet the National Minimum Wage.

11.7 Bonuses and variable pay

Northstar operates a discretionary **Annual Performance Bonus** for the financial year 1 April to 31 March, paid in July. The scheme is non-contractual: the company decides whether a bonus pool exists and the amount of any individual award. To be considered, an employee must have joined on or before 31 December of the financial year concerned and be employed, and not under notice given or received, on the payment date. Awards are pro-rated for part-time employees and for part-year service. Receiving a bonus in one year creates no entitlement in future years.

11.8 Commission

Eligible sales employees participate in the Sales Commission Plan issued each financial year. Commission is contractual to the extent set out in the plan document and is paid quarterly in arrears. Commission disputes are raised with the Head of Sales Operations within 30 days of the commission statement.

11.9 Overtime payments

Approved overtime (section 5.5) is paid in the payroll following approval, provided the TimeTrack entry has been approved by the payroll cut-off.

11.10 Deductions from pay

Northstar may deduct from pay only where:

- the deduction is required or authorised by law (for example, income tax, National Insurance, student loan repayments, pension contributions under auto-enrolment and court-ordered attachments of earnings);
- the deduction is authorised by a written term of the employment contract that the employee has been given before the deduction (for example, recovery of a negative holiday balance under section 6.16); or
- the employee has given prior written consent to the deduction; or
- the deduction is to recover an overpayment of wages or expenses.

Northstar does not make deductions for any other reason, and will not make a deduction that is unlawful, including one that would take pay below the National Minimum Wage except as the law permits.

11.11 Pension

Northstar automatically enrols eligible employees into the Northstar Group Personal Pension, in line with workplace pension auto-enrolment law. The statutory minimum total contribution is 8% of qualifying earnings (at least 3% from the employer), where qualifying earnings for 2026/27 are earnings between £6,240 and £50,270 a year. Northstar contributes **5% of basic salary** when the employee contributes at least **4% of basic salary**; contributions can be made by salary sacrifice. Employees may opt out, but will then lose the employer contribution, and Northstar will re-enrol eligible employees periodically as the law requires.

11.12 Benefits

Table 11.12 — Northstar benefits and eligibility

Benefit	Eligibility	Notes
Life assurance	All employees from day one	4 x basic salary. Complete an expression of wish form in PeopleHub.
Private medical insurance	Employees who have completed probation	Employee-only cover. Family cover may be added at the employee's own cost through payroll. Taxable benefit.
Employee Assistance Programme	All employees from day one, and their household members	Confidential 24/7 support line and counselling sessions.
Cycle-to-work scheme	Employees who have completed probation	Salary sacrifice; cycle value up to £2,000.
Eye tests for display screen users	All employees who use display screen equipment	Up to £25 per eye test and up to £60 towards glasses needed specifically for screen use, every 2 years.
Learning budget	Employees, see section 13.6	£1,000 per financial year.

Benefits enrolment for new joiners must be completed within **30 days** of becoming eligible; otherwise, employees can join in the annual enrolment window in March. Benefits not listed in this handbook or a supporting standard are not offered.

11.13 Tax documentation

Employees receive a P60 by 31 May each year, a P45 when they leave, and, where they receive taxable benefits, details of those benefits by 6 July. Payroll cannot give personal tax advice.

11.14 Overpayments

If an employee is overpaid, they must tell Payroll as soon as they notice. Northstar will agree a repayment plan in writing, normally over the same number of months in which the overpayment occurred and no longer than **12 months**. If the employee leaves before the overpayment is repaid, the outstanding amount is recovered from final pay, and any remaining balance is requested in writing.

12 Expenses and business travel

This section is a summary. The authoritative detailed rules, including international limits and the reimbursability decision table, are in the Expenses and Business Travel Policy NDS-FIN-EXP-003 v1.1.

12.1 Principles

Northstar reimburses reasonable, necessary expenses incurred wholly and exclusively for Northstar business, where the claim is supported by evidence, submitted on time and approved by the right person. Employees should spend company money as carefully as their own and choose the most cost-effective option that meets the business need.

12.2 Pre-approval

The following require approval **before** the cost is incurred: any overnight stay; all international travel (Director approval and a travel-risk check); any single item over £250; client entertainment; first-class rail, premium economy or business-class flights; and conferences or training paid from the learning budget.

12.3 Claim deadline and late claims

Expense claim deadline

Submit claims in ExpenseFlow within **30 calendar days** of the date the expense was incurred. Claims submitted 31 to 90 calendar days after the expense require a written explanation and Head of Department approval. Claims submitted more than 90 calendar days after the expense are not reimbursed, unless the Finance Director approves an exception (for example, where the employee was on long-term sickness absence). Leavers must submit all claims within **10 working days** after their leaving date.

12.4 Receipts and evidence

An itemised receipt is required for every expense except mileage (which requires a journey log showing date, start and end points, business purpose and miles) and the overnight incidental allowance. A card-terminal slip alone is not an itemised receipt. If a receipt is lost, the employee may submit a missing-receipt declaration with alternative evidence (such as a bank or card statement) for items up to **£75**, no more than **2** times per calendar quarter.

12.5 Summary of limits (UK travel)

Table 12.5 — Illustrative UK expense limits (detail in NDS-FIN-EXP-003 section 4)

Expense	Limit	Eligibility conditions
Breakfast	£12	Only when staying overnight and breakfast is not included in the room rate.
Lunch	£15	Only when travelling on business away from the normal workplace for more than 5 hours.
Evening meal	£35	Only when staying overnight, or when business travel means returning home after 20:00.
Daily meal cap (UK overnight)	£55 per day	Total of breakfast, lunch and evening meal on any day of an overnight trip.
Hotel — London	£180 per night	Room only, including taxes. Pre-approval required.
Hotel — elsewhere in the UK	£120 per night	Room only, including taxes. Pre-approval required.
Overnight incidental allowance	£5 per night (UK)	No receipt required. Covers personal incidental costs.
Car mileage (own vehicle)	55p per mile for the first 10,000 business miles in the tax year; 25p per mile after that	Business miles only; normal commuting miles are excluded. Rates follow HMRC approved mileage rates for 2026/27.
Rail	Standard class	First class only for journeys scheduled over 3 hours with Head of Department pre-approval, or as a reasonable adjustment.
Taxi	Up to £50 per journey	Only where no reasonable public transport exists, between 22:00 and 06:00, when carrying heavy equipment, or for safety or accessibility reasons. Above £50 needs Head of Department approval.
Client entertainment	£60 per head, including drinks	Head of Department pre-approval; record attendees and business purpose. More than £100 per head requires Director approval and an entry in the gifts and hospitality register.
Home office allowance	£300 once every 3 years	After probation, hybrid or remote employees only (section 10.4).

12.6 Approval thresholds

Table 12.6 — Expense approval matrix (total value of a single claim)

Claim value	Approvers required
Up to £250.00	Line manager
£250.01 to £1,000.00	Line manager and Head of Department
£1,000.01 to £5,000.00	Line manager, Head of Department and Director
Over £5,000.00	Line manager, Head of Department, Director and Finance Director

No one may approve their own expenses, expenses for a trip they attended as the most senior person, or expenses of a person with whom they have a declared conflict of interest. In those cases, the next level of approver approves instead. Splitting a single expense into several claims to stay below a threshold is prohibited.

12.7 Corporate cards, currency and reimbursement

- Corporate cards are issued to employees expected to travel at least 6 times a year, with Director approval. Personal use is prohibited; accidental personal use must be repaid within 10 working days. Transactions must be reconciled in ExpenseFlow within 30 days of the statement date.
- For expenses paid in a foreign currency, the claim is made in pounds sterling using the amount shown on the card statement (including card fees) or, for cash, Finance's published monthly exchange rate for the month of the expense.
- Claims fully approved by the payroll cut-off (the 10th of the month) are reimbursed in that month's salary payment on the 25th. Claims approved after the cut-off are paid the following month.

12.8 Personal expenses, duplicates, rejections and fraud

Personal costs (for example, alcohol outside approved client entertainment, minibar items, fines, upgrades not approved in advance, and travel between home and the normal workplace) are not reimbursed. Duplicate claims, including claiming for something already paid by a corporate card or by a customer, are rejected. An employee whose claim is rejected may ask the next-level approver to review it within 10 working days. Suspected expense fraud is investigated by Finance and People Operations and may be treated as gross misconduct.

12.9 Responsibilities

Table 12.9 — Expense responsibilities

Role	Responsibilities
Claimant	Obtain pre-approval where needed; spend reasonably; keep receipts; submit accurate claims on time; repay any overpayment.
Approver	Check business purpose, policy limits and evidence before approving; approve within 5 working days; never approve own claims or claims where conflicted.
Finance	Audit claims, apply limits, process reimbursement, monitor fraud indicators and report trends to Heads of Department.

13 Performance management and development

13.1 Objectives

Every employee has 3 to 6 objectives for the financial year (1 April to 31 March), agreed with their line manager and recorded in PeopleHub by **30 April** (or within 30 days of joining). Objectives should be specific and measurable and include at least one development objective.

13.2 One-to-ones and feedback

Line managers hold one-to-one meetings with each direct report at least **every 2 weeks**, and never less than monthly. One-to-ones cover wellbeing, progress against objectives, feedback in both directions and development. Feedback should be timely, specific and based on observed behaviour or results.

13.3 Reviews and ratings

Table 13.3 — Annual performance cycle

Point in cycle	Activity
April	Objective-setting for the new financial year (complete by 30 April).
October	Mid-year review: written check-in recorded in PeopleHub by 31 October.
April to May	Annual review: self-assessment, manager assessment, calibration and rating. Ratings confirmed by 31 May.

Ratings use a 5-point scale: 5 Exceptional; 4 Exceeds expectations; 3 Fully meets expectations; 2 Partially meets expectations; 1 Does not meet expectations. Heads of Department hold calibration meetings to ensure consistent and fair ratings. Managers must take account of approved absences (including family leave and disability-related absence) and agreed adjustments when assessing performance, and must not penalise employees for them.

13.4 Promotion and career development

Promotions are considered in two rounds a year, effective **1 April** and **1 October**. A promotion requires a manager nomination, an evidence pack against the Northstar career framework for the target grade, and approval at a calibration panel. Employees may also apply for internal vacancies at a higher grade (section 3.7). Career conversations take place at least twice a year as part of one-to-ones.

13.5 Performance improvement plans

Where performance falls below the required standard, the line manager first provides informal support for at least **4 weeks**, with clear expectations and regular feedback. If performance does not improve, a formal performance improvement plan (PIP) may be started with People Operations' involvement.

- A PIP normally lasts **8 weeks** (minimum 6, maximum 12) and sets measurable objectives, the support provided and weekly check-ins.
- A PIP may be extended once by up to **4 weeks**.
- At the end, the outcome is success, extension, or referral to a formal capability hearing under section 15.8.
- The employee may be accompanied at formal capability hearings in the same way as at disciplinary hearings.

13.6 Training, certifications, mentoring and learning budgets

- Every employee has a **learning budget of £1,000 per financial year** (1 April to 31 March) for courses, conferences, books and certification exams relevant to their role or career framework. The budget is not reduced for part-time employees; for employees joining part-way through the financial year it is pro-rated by complete months remaining. Unused budget does not carry over.
- Spending from the learning budget requires line manager pre-approval in PeopleHub.

- Any single course or programme costing more than **£1,500** (which needs additional funding approved by the Head of Department) requires a study agreement. If the employee resigns within 12 months of completing it, they repay 100% of the cost if they leave within 6 months, and 50% if they leave between 6 and 12 months. Repayment does not apply if employment ends by redundancy.
- Certification exam fees are funded for the first attempt and one resit.
- Mandatory training (section 3.6) is repeated annually and must be completed by the published deadline.
- Northstar runs a mentoring programme with two intakes a year; any employee who has completed probation may apply to be a mentee.

13.7 Performance concerns and misconduct concerns

Table 13.7 — Distinguishing performance from conduct

Issue type	Examples	Procedure
Performance (capability)	Code quality consistently below standard; missing agreed deadlines despite support; lack of a required skill	Informal support, PIP (section 13.5), capability hearing (section 15.8)
Ill-health capability	Long-term or frequent absence affecting ability to do the job	Absence management (section 7) and capability (section 15.8)
Misconduct	Deliberately ignoring instructions; inappropriate behaviour; breach of policy; falsifying a timesheet	Disciplinary procedure (section 15)

If a performance issue turns out to involve deliberate wrongdoing, the manager should pause the PIP and seek People Operations' advice on moving to the disciplinary procedure.

14 Standards of conduct and conflicts of interest

14.1 Professional behaviour

Employees are expected to act with integrity, treat colleagues, customers and suppliers with respect, follow lawful and reasonable instructions, comply with Northstar policies and customer site rules, and represent Northstar professionally.

14.2 Confidentiality

Employees must protect Northstar's and customers' confidential information during and after employment. Confidential information must be accessed only where needed for the employee's role, handled according to its classification (section 19.4), and never discussed in public places or shared with people who do not need it. Confidentiality obligations continue after employment ends.

14.3 Conflicts of interest

A conflict of interest arises where an employee's personal interests, relationships or outside activities could influence, or appear to influence, their decisions at work. Employees must declare actual or potential conflicts in the PeopleHub Declarations register within **10 working days** of becoming aware of them and confirm their declarations annually by **31 May**. Declarations are reviewed by the line manager and, where needed, the Head of Risk and Compliance, who agree how the conflict will be managed (for example, by removing the employee from a decision).

14.4 Gifts and hospitality

Table 14.4 — Gifts and hospitality received

Value (per gift, or per person per event)	Rule
Up to £25	May be accepted; no record needed unless from the same source more than 3 times in a year.
£25.01 to £100	May be accepted; must be recorded in the gifts and hospitality register within 5 working days.
Over £100	Requires Director approval **before** acceptance and a register entry.
Any value, during an active tender, procurement or contract negotiation with the giver	Must be declined.
Cash, vouchers, gift cards or loans	Must always be declined, whatever the value.

Gifts and hospitality offered by Northstar to customers follow the client entertainment limits in section 12.5. Any gift or hospitality offered to a public official requires prior approval from the Head of Risk and Compliance.

14.5 Outside employment and personal business activities

Employees must obtain written approval from their line manager and People Operations before taking up any outside employment, consultancy, directorship or business activity that: involves a Northstar customer, supplier or competitor; could use Northstar time, equipment or information; or exceeds 8 hours per week. Approval will not be unreasonably refused but may be withdrawn if a conflict arises. Unpaid voluntary roles and personal open-source contributions that do not use Northstar information do not require approval but must not conflict with Northstar's interests.

14.6 Intellectual property and company property

Work products created by employees in the course of their employment, including software, documentation, designs and inventions, belong to Northstar to the extent provided by law and the employment contract. Company property, including equipment, data and software licences, must be used for business purposes and returned on request or when employment ends (section 20 and section 22).

14.7 Social media

Employees may mention that they work for Northstar but must not disclose confidential information, comment on customers or customer projects, speak on Northstar's behalf without Communications team approval, or post content that could amount to harassment of colleagues. Personal views should be clearly personal.

14.8 Client relationships

Personal relationships (including close friendships, family relationships and romantic relationships) with customer staff who make decisions about Northstar contracts must be declared under section 14.3.

14.9 Anti-bribery

Northstar has zero tolerance of bribery and corruption, in line with the Bribery Act 2010. Employees must never offer, give, request or accept a bribe or a facilitation payment, directly or through a third party. Concerns must be reported immediately to the Head of Risk and Compliance at compliance@northstar.example or through the Speak Up line.

14.10 Conflict of interest examples

Table 14.10 — Conflict of interest scenarios and required action

Scenario	Required action
Supplier relationship: an engineer's partner is a sales director at a cloud-monitoring vendor that Northstar is evaluating.	Declare within 10 working days. The engineer must not take part in the evaluation or contract decision.
Hiring relatives: a Head of Department's nephew applies for a graduate role in the same department.	Declare before shortlisting. The Head of Department must not sit on the panel, see confidential candidate scores, or line-manage the relative directly or indirectly if appointed.
Financial interest: a consultant owns shares worth more than £10,000, or more than 1% of the share capital, in a Northstar competitor or a supplier they deal with.	Declare. The Head of Risk and Compliance decides whether additional controls are needed.
Outside consulting: a senior engineer is asked to provide paid weekend architecture advice to a fintech start-up that is a prospective Northstar customer.	Seek approval before agreeing. Approval will normally be refused because the start-up is a prospective customer.

14.11 Reporting suspected misconduct

Employees should report suspected misconduct to their line manager, People Operations or, where appropriate, through the whistleblowing procedure in section 16. Reports are handled confidentially as far as possible.

15 Disciplinary and grievance procedures

These procedures follow the Acas Code of Practice on Disciplinary and Grievance Procedures. They are not contractual and may be adapted where appropriate, but the core steps of fair investigation, a meeting, the right to be accompanied and the right of appeal will always be followed.

15.1 Types of issue

Table 15.1 — Distinguishing workplace issues

Issue	Description	Procedure
Misconduct	Breach of rules or expected standards of behaviour, such as lateness, minor policy breaches or inappropriate comments	Disciplinary (sections 15.3 to 15.5)
Gross misconduct	Serious misconduct that may justify dismissal without notice, such as theft, fraud (including expense or timesheet fraud), violence, serious harassment, serious breach of information security, or deliberately disclosing Restricted information	Disciplinary; possible suspension
Capability	Inability to perform the role to the required standard because of skills, performance or health	Section 13.5 and section 15.8
Redundancy	The business need for work of a particular kind has ceased or diminished	Section 22.2
Grievance	A concern, problem or complaint an employee raises about their work, working conditions or relationships with colleagues	Section 15.6
General workplace disagreement	A difference of opinion about work approach that does not involve a breach of standards	Informal discussion and, if needed, mediation

15.2 Informal resolution

Minor conduct issues should normally be resolved informally by the line manager through a private conversation, with a brief note recorded. Informal action is not a disciplinary sanction.

15.3 Investigation and suspension

Formal disciplinary matters are investigated by an investigating officer who will not make the final decision. The investigation may include interviews, documents, system logs and access-card records. Employees may be suspended on full pay where necessary to protect the investigation or the business; suspension is not a sanction and is reviewed at least every 2 weeks.

15.4 Disciplinary hearing and representation

The employee receives a written invitation at least **5 working days** before the hearing, setting out the allegations and possible consequences and including the evidence. Employees have a statutory right to be accompanied at disciplinary and grievance hearings by a work colleague or a trade union representative. The companion may address the hearing and confer with the employee but may not answer questions on the employee's behalf. If the chosen companion is unavailable, the hearing may be postponed to a reasonable alternative time within 5 working days of the original date. Further reasonable adjustments to the hearing (for example, extra breaks or written questions in advance) will be made where needed.

15.5 Outcomes, sanctions and appeals

Table 15.5 — Disciplinary sanctions

Sanction	Duration on file
First written warning	6 months
Final written warning	12 months
Dismissal with notice (or pay in lieu of notice)	Not applicable
Summary dismissal without notice for gross misconduct	Not applicable

As an alternative to dismissal, Northstar may consider demotion or transfer where appropriate. The outcome is confirmed in writing within **5 working days** of the hearing. The employee may appeal in writing within **5 working days** of receiving the outcome letter, stating the grounds. The appeal is heard by a more senior manager not previously involved, normally within **10 working days** of receiving the appeal. The appeal decision is final.

15.6 Grievance procedure

1. **Informal:** raise the issue with the line manager (or another manager if the issue involves the line manager).
2. **Formal:** submit a written grievance to the line manager, or to the Head of Department or People Operations if the grievance concerns the line manager. People Operations acknowledges it within **3 working days**.
3. **Grievance meeting:** normally held within **10 working days** of receipt. The employee may be accompanied as set out in section 15.4.
4. **Outcome:** confirmed in writing, normally within **5 working days** of the meeting (or with an explanation if further investigation is needed).
5. **Appeal:** within **5 working days** of the outcome letter, to a more senior manager; the appeal meeting is normally held within **10 working days**. The appeal decision is final.

Where a grievance is raised during a disciplinary process, the disciplinary process may be suspended briefly to deal with the grievance, or both may be dealt with together where they are related.

15.7 Confidentiality and records

Disciplinary and grievance matters are handled as confidentially as possible. Confidentiality cannot be guaranteed absolutely, because the person responding to allegations must be able to understand and answer them, witnesses may need to be interviewed, and information may need to be disclosed to decision-makers, advisers, courts or regulators. Records are kept in the restricted employee relations area of PeopleHub and retained in line with section 18.4. Expired warnings are disregarded for future disciplinary decisions but remain on file.

15.8 Capability procedure

Capability hearings (for performance after an unsuccessful PIP, or for ill health after medical advice) follow the same steps as disciplinary hearings: written invitation, right to be accompanied, written outcome and right of appeal. Possible outcomes include further support, redeployment, adjustment of duties, a final capability warning or dismissal on notice.

> **Unfair dismissal qualifying period [legal review flag]**
> At the date of this handbook, the qualifying period for ordinary unfair dismissal claims was 2 years' continuous service. Under the Employment Rights Act 2025, the qualifying period is expected to reduce to 6 months for dismissals taking effect on or after 1 January 2027. People Operations must confirm the position in force before any dismissal. Northstar applies fair procedures to all employees, regardless of length of service.

16 Whistleblowing and reporting concerns

16.1 What whistleblowing covers

Whistleblowing is reporting suspected wrongdoing that affects others or the public interest — for example, a criminal offence, fraud, a breach of a legal obligation, a danger to health and safety, environmental damage, a miscarriage of justice, or the deliberate concealment of any of these. Under the Public Interest Disclosure Act 1998, workers who make a qualifying ("protected") disclosure in the reasonable belief that it is in the public interest are protected from detriment and dismissal for doing so.

16.2 Whistleblowing and personal grievances

A personal grievance (for example, a complaint about one's own pay, workload or treatment by a manager) is normally dealt with under the grievance procedure in section 15.6. Some situations overlap: a complaint that a manager is pressuring staff to falsify customer billing affects both the individual and the public interest, and may be handled as whistleblowing. If unsure, raise the concern and Northstar will decide the right procedure, keeping you informed.

16.3 How to raise a concern

Concerns can be raised with any of the following:

- the employee's line manager or Head of Department;
- the Head of Risk and Compliance (compliance@northstar.example);
- speakup@northstar.example;
- the independent **Speak Up line**, operated by an independent third-party provider and available 24/7 by web form and telephone via the intranet, which accepts anonymous reports.

Concerns involving a manager or Director should be raised with someone outside their reporting line or through the Speak Up line. Concerns involving the Chief Executive Officer should be raised with the Chair of the Audit Committee via the Speak Up line. Workers may also report to an appropriate prescribed person or body (for example, a regulator), as permitted by law.

16.4 How concerns are handled

The Head of Risk and Compliance acknowledges the concern within **5 working days**, completes an initial assessment within **10 working days**, and appoints an independent investigator where needed. The person raising the concern is given feedback on progress where appropriate, normally within 3 months, although some outcomes cannot be shared because of confidentiality or legal reasons.

16.5 Confidentiality and protection from retaliation

Northstar will protect the identity of a person raising a concern where they ask for this, unless disclosure is required by law. Anyone who victimises or retaliates against a whistleblower will face disciplinary action. Deliberately making a false report is a disciplinary matter.

16.6 Urgent matters

If there is an immediate risk to life or health, call emergency services on 999 first, then Northstar Security. Suspected personal-data breaches must also be reported immediately to the Data Protection Officer (section 18.7); suspected security incidents to the IT Security team (section 19.10).

17 Health, safety and wellbeing

17.1 Responsibilities

Table 17.1 — Health and safety responsibilities

Role	Responsibilities
Employees	Take reasonable care of their own and others' safety; follow procedures and training; report hazards, accidents and near misses; complete DSE assessments; use equipment properly.
Line managers	Ensure team members complete training and assessments; act on reported hazards; carry out or arrange risk assessments for their team's activities, including lone working and travel; support wellbeing and stress risk assessments.
Head of Facilities and Health and Safety	Owns the health and safety management system, fire safety, first aid and incident investigation; reports to the Executive Leadership Team.
Executive Leadership Team	Overall accountability for health and safety.

17.2 Office safety and fire procedures

- Fire alarms are tested every Wednesday at 10:00 at the Manchester office. Any alarm at another time means evacuate immediately by the nearest exit to the designated assembly point; do not use lifts.
- Fire wardens and first aiders are listed on the noticeboard on each floor and on the intranet.
- Visitors must be signed in and escorted.

17.3 Accidents, near misses and hazards

All accidents, injuries, near misses and hazards, whether in the office, at a customer site, while travelling or while working at home, must be reported using the PeopleHub Safety form within **24 hours**. Serious injuries must be reported to the line manager immediately. The Health and Safety team assesses whether an incident must be reported to the Health and Safety Executive under RIDDOR and makes any required report within the statutory timescales.

17.4 Display screen equipment and ergonomics

All employees who use display screen equipment as a significant part of their work complete a DSE self-assessment within 2 weeks of starting and whenever their workstation changes. Eye tests are provided under section 11.12. Ergonomic equipment needs identified in the assessment are provided by Facilities or through the home office allowance (section 10.4).

17.5 Remote-working safety

Home workers must keep their work area free of trip hazards, use equipment safely and take regular screen breaks. Northstar may ask for photographs of the home workstation to support the DSE assessment. Lone workers at customer sites must follow the customer's site safety rules and the lone-working check-in procedure agreed with their manager.

17.6 Travel safety

Travel to countries rated medium or high risk on the travel-risk register requires a travel-risk assessment and a daily check-in with the Travel desk. Employees must keep emergency contact details current in PeopleHub and carry the Northstar travel assistance card when travelling abroad.

17.7 Workplace stress and mental wellbeing

Northstar uses the Health and Safety Executive's Management Standards approach to manage work-related stress. Employees experiencing stress should speak to their manager, People Operations or a Mental Health First Aider (at least 1 per 50 employees). Managers must complete a stress risk assessment with an employee who reports work-related stress. The Employee Assistance Programme provides confidential counselling 24/7.

17.8 Risk assessments

Risk assessments are carried out for office activities, new and expectant mothers, young workers, lone working, home working, travel to higher-risk destinations, and events. Pregnant employees should tell their manager as early as they feel able so that a pregnancy risk assessment can be carried out.

17.9 Emergency contacts

In an emergency, call **999** (or 112). Then contact Northstar Security on the 24/7 internal line listed in Appendix B. Employees must keep at least one emergency contact up to date in PeopleHub.

18 Data protection, confidentiality and records

Northstar is a controller of personal data about its employees, candidates and customers' staff, and complies with the UK General Data Protection Regulation (UK GDPR) and the Data Protection Act 2018, as amended. The Data Protection Officer (DPO) can be contacted at dpo@northstar.example. Detailed security and data-handling rules are in NDS-SEC-ITG-004.

18.1 Employee personal data and privacy notices

Northstar processes employee data for purposes including recruitment, payroll, benefits, performance management, health and safety, legal compliance and security monitoring. The Employee Privacy Notice on the intranet explains what is collected, why, the lawful basis, who it is shared with, how long it is kept and employees' rights. Candidates receive a separate Candidate Privacy Notice.

18.2 Lawful and appropriate access and data minimisation

Employees may access personal data only where their role requires it and only to the extent needed. Managers may see the personal data of their direct reports needed for line management, but not health details, bank details or grievance records unless they are involved in the specific matter. Collect only the minimum data needed for a purpose; do not create unofficial copies such as personal spreadsheets of team absence reasons.

18.3 Accuracy

Employees must keep their own details in PeopleHub accurate and update them within **10 working days** of a change (for example, address, emergency contact or name). Managers must correct inaccurate data they hold.

18.4 Retention schedule

Table 18.4 — Retention periods for employee-related records

Record type	Retention period	Owner
Personnel file (contract, written statement, changes to terms)	6 years after employment ends	People Operations
Payroll, tax and National Insurance records	6 years from the end of the tax year to which they relate	Payroll
Right-to-work check copies	For the duration of employment plus 2 years	People Operations
Recruitment records for unsuccessful candidates	6 months after the hiring decision	Talent Acquisition
Sickness absence records and fit notes	3 years after the end of the leave year in which the absence occurred	People Operations
Occupational Health reports	6 years after employment ends	People Operations
Disciplinary, grievance and capability records	6 years after employment ends	People Operations
Accident book and incident records	3 years from the date of the entry	Health and Safety
Expense claims and receipts	6 years after the end of the financial year	Finance
Timesheets (TimeTrack)	6 years after the end of the financial year	Finance
Access-card logs	90 days	Facilities
CCTV footage	30 days, unless required for an investigation	Facilities
Prompts and outputs in approved generative AI tools	90 days (see NDS-SEC-ITG-004)	IT Security
Data subject access request case files	2 years after the response	Data Protection Officer
Whistleblowing case files	6 years after the case is closed	Head of Risk and Compliance

Records needed for an ongoing legal claim, investigation or regulatory request are kept until the matter ends, even if the normal period has expired.

18.5 Data subject rights and access requests

Individuals have rights to access, rectify, erase and restrict the processing of their personal data, and to object to certain processing. A data subject access request (DSAR) can be made in any form, including verbally. Any employee who receives a request must forward it to dpo@northstar.example within **1 working day** and must not respond themselves. Northstar responds within **one month** of receipt; this can be extended by up to two further months where requests are complex or numerous, in which case the requester is told within the first month.

18.6 Records of processing

The DPO maintains Northstar's record of processing activities. Any new system, AI tool or process that uses personal data must be notified to the DPO before launch, and a Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) completed where processing is likely to result in high risk.

18.7 Personal-data incidents and breaches

Reporting a suspected personal-data incident

1. Report it **immediately**, and in any case within **1 hour** of discovery, to security@northstar.example and dpo@northstar.example, or call the 24/7 security line. 2. Do not try to investigate yourself, delete evidence, or contact affected people unless instructed. 3. The DPO assesses the incident. Where a personal-data breach is likely to result in a risk to individuals, Northstar must notify the Information Commissioner's Office without undue delay and, where feasible, within 72 hours of becoming aware of it, and must inform affected individuals without undue delay where the risk is high.

Examples of personal-data incidents: an email containing a salary spreadsheet sent to the wrong recipient; a lost unencrypted USB stick; access permissions on a shared folder accidentally opened to everyone; employee data pasted into an unapproved AI tool.

18.8 Disclosure to third parties

Do not confirm any information about current or former employees to callers, recruiters, landlords, lenders or the media. Refer all requests to People Operations. Requests from the police or other authorities must be referred to the DPO. Customers receive employee personal data only where necessary for the contract (for example, names and screening confirmations for site access).

18.9 Secure disposal

Paper containing Internal, Confidential or Restricted information must go in locked confidential waste bins. Devices and storage media are returned to IT for certified wiping or destruction. Never put documents containing personal data in general waste or recycling, including at home.

18.10 Avoiding exposure of sensitive information

- Use the minimum data needed — for example, share an anonymised summary rather than a full extract.
- Check recipients before sending; turn off email auto-complete for external addresses where possible.
- Share files with named people, not "anyone with the link".
- Never use real employee or customer personal data in test environments, demos or AI prompts unless explicitly approved.

19 IT acceptable use, information security and AI usage

This section summarises the IT Security, Data Protection and Generative AI Policy NDS-SEC-ITG-004 v2.0, which is the authoritative detailed rule. Breach of these rules may lead to disciplinary action and, for serious breaches, may be gross misconduct.

19.1 Company devices and approved software

Use only Northstar-managed devices for Northstar work, except as permitted for personal devices in section 19.7. Install only software from the Northstar Software Centre or approved by IT. Do not disable security tools, encryption, updates or endpoint monitoring.

19.2 Passwords, multifactor authentication and access control

Passwords must be at least **14 characters**, unique to each system and stored only in the approved Northstar password manager. Multifactor authentication (MFA) is mandatory for all Northstar systems. Never share passwords or MFA codes, and never approve an MFA prompt you did not initiate. Access is granted on a least-privilege basis and reviewed quarterly by system owners.

19.3 Phishing and suspicious messages

Report suspicious emails using the "Report Phish" button in Outlook, and suspicious calls or chat messages to the IT Service Desk. Do not click links, open attachments or reply. If you think you may have entered credentials or opened something malicious, report it as a security incident immediately (section 19.10).

19.4 Data classification

Table 19.4 — Northstar data classification levels

Level	Definition and examples	Key handling rules
Public	Information approved for public release: website content, published case studies, job adverts.	No restrictions.
Internal	Information for Northstar staff and authorised contractors: this handbook, the intranet, internal process guides, organisation charts.	Share only with Northstar staff and authorised contractors.
Confidential	Information whose disclosure could harm Northstar, customers or individuals: customer project documents, source code, financial forecasts, contracts, most employee personal data.	Need-to-know access; encrypt in transit and at rest; share externally only through approved secure sharing with a business need.
Restricted	The most sensitive information: special category personal data (for example, health data), salary and bank details, security credentials and keys, customer production data, data covered by customer clearance requirements, M&A information.	Named-person access only; never on removable media, personal devices or public Wi-Fi; never in any generative AI tool; access from outside the UK only with written CISO approval.

19.5 Removable media

USB storage is blocked by default. IT may approve encrypted company-issued removable media for a specific, time-limited business need. Restricted information must never be copied to removable media.

19.6 Secure document sharing

Use the approved document management platform. External sharing of Confidential information requires named recipients, expiry dates and, for Restricted information, encryption and Information Owner approval. Do not use personal email or personal cloud storage for Northstar information.

19.7 Personal devices

Personal phones and tablets may be used for Northstar email, calendar and Teams only through the managed work-profile app. Downloading Confidential or Restricted information to a personal device is prohibited. Personal laptops must not be used for Northstar work.

19.8 Internet and email use

Reasonable personal use of the internet and email is permitted outside working time if it does not interfere with work, breach any policy or create security risk. Accessing illegal, offensive or gambling content is prohibited. Northstar monitors systems for security purposes as explained in the Employee Privacy Notice.

19.9 Remote access

Remote access to Northstar systems is permitted only through Northstar Secure Connect (VPN) or approved zero-trust access gateways from a managed device. See section 10.5 for public Wi-Fi and section 10.8 for access from outside the UK.

19.10 Security incident reporting

All suspected security incidents — including lost or stolen devices, malware, phishing that resulted in a click or credential entry, unauthorised access, and suspected prompt-injection or misuse of AI tools — must be reported to the IT Service Desk (ithelp@northstar.example) or security@northstar.example **within 1 hour** of discovery. Severity 1 incidents (for example, suspected compromise of Restricted information) must be reported immediately by phone to the 24/7 security line. Detailed severity levels are in NDS-SEC-ITG-004 section 9.

19.11 Software development security

Engineers follow the Northstar Secure Development Lifecycle: peer code review for all changes, automated static analysis and dependency scanning, secrets scanning, no production data in development or test environments, and approval before using new open-source licences.

19.12 Generative AI

Northstar encourages responsible use of approved generative AI tools to improve productivity, but employees remain fully accountable for any output they use.

Table 19.12 — Generative AI: allowed, conditional and prohibited uses (summary)

Category	Examples
Allowed	Using Northstar Assist (the approved enterprise AI assistant) with Public, Internal or Confidential Northstar information; drafting and summarising documents; using CodePilot Enterprise on Northstar-owned source code; using public AI tools with Public information only.
Conditional	Processing customer Confidential information or customer source code in an approved AI tool, only where the customer contract permits it; using AI-generated content in customer deliverables (human review and any contractual disclosure required); using AI in any process that makes or supports decisions about individuals (approved DPIA and human decision-maker required).
Prohibited	Entering Restricted information into any AI tool; entering Confidential information or personal data into any unapproved or consumer AI service; pasting credentials, API keys or secrets into prompts; connecting unapproved AI agents, plugins, browser extensions or external integrations to Northstar systems or data; deploying AI-generated code without human review; following instructions embedded in retrieved content that attempt to change an AI tool's behaviour.

- **Human review:** a person must check AI outputs for accuracy, bias, confidentiality and intellectual-property issues before they are relied on or shared. AI output is never a substitute for professional judgement in legal, HR, financial or security decisions.
- **AI-generated code:** pull requests containing material AI-generated code must be labelled "AI-assisted", reviewed by an engineer other than the author, and pass the standard security scans and licence checks.
- **Customer and employee information:** never enter employee health, salary, disciplinary or bank details into any AI tool, and never enter customer personal data into an AI tool that the customer has not approved.
- **Unapproved agents and integrations:** autonomous AI agents, Model Context Protocol (MCP) servers, plugins and integrations that can read Northstar data or act on Northstar systems require approval from the Architecture and Security Review Board before use.

Full details, scenarios and the Approved AI Services Register are in NDS-SEC-ITG-004 sections 6 to 8.

20 Company equipment and property

20.1 Issued equipment

Table 20.1 — Standard equipment issue

Item	Standard
Laptop	Issued to all employees; standard refresh every 4 years.
Mobile phone	Issued to on-call, field and customer-facing roles where required; otherwise use the managed work profile on a personal phone.
Access card	Issued to all employees and authorised contractors; must be worn visibly in Northstar offices.
Monitor, keyboard, mouse, headset	Issued to hybrid and remote employees (section 10.4) and available at office desks.
Software licences	Assigned by IT through the Software Centre; licences may not be transferred between people.

20.2 Requesting equipment

Additional or replacement equipment is requested through the IT Service Desk with line manager approval. Equipment needed as a reasonable adjustment is requested through People Operations.

20.3 Damage, loss and theft

- Report loss or theft of any device or access card to the IT Service Desk **immediately and in any case within 1 hour** of discovery, so that it can be locked and wiped remotely. Loss or theft is also a security incident (section 19.10).
- Report theft to the police within **24 hours** and record the crime reference number in the IT ticket.
- Report accidental damage to the IT Service Desk as soon as possible. Northstar does not normally recover the cost of accidental damage. Where loss or damage results from deliberate misuse or gross negligence, Northstar may recover a reasonable contribution only with the employee's written agreement or where the contract permits.

20.4 Repairs and inventory

Only IT may repair Northstar equipment or arrange repairs. Every item is recorded in the IT asset register against the employee's name. Employees confirm the equipment they hold in the annual asset attestation in January.

20.5 Acceptable use

Company equipment is for business use, with limited personal use permitted under section 19.8. Family members and others must not use Northstar devices.

20.6 Returning equipment

Equipment return deadlines

- **Office-based leavers** return all equipment and their access card to IT on their **last working day**.
- **Remote or hybrid leavers** return all equipment within **5 working days** after their leaving date, using the prepaid courier arranged by IT. Access cards may be posted with the equipment.
- If equipment has not been returned within **10 working days** after the leaving date, IT escalates to People Operations, who send a written reminder and may take recovery action. Any deduction from final pay is made only where the contract permits or the employee has agreed in writing.
- Employees returning from long-term absence or moving role return any equipment no longer needed within 10 working days of IT's request.

21 Complaints involving customers and workplace incidents

21.1 Scope

This section covers escalations arising from customer interactions, inappropriate behaviour by customers or other third parties, security incidents, professional-conduct complaints, and incidents at customer sites.

21.2 Incident severity and reporting times

Table 21.2 — Workplace and customer incident severity

Severity	Examples	Report to and by when
Severity 1 — Critical	Immediate risk to life or serious injury; suspected compromise of Restricted information; physical threat at a customer site	Emergency services first if needed (999). Then call the Northstar 24/7 security line **immediately**, and the line manager.
Severity 2 — High	Harassment, threats or abuse from a customer; injury needing medical treatment; confirmed exposure of Confidential information	Line manager and the relevant team (People Operations, Health and Safety or IT Security) **within 1 hour**.
Severity 3 — Medium	A customer complaint alleging unprofessional conduct by a Northstar employee; a minor injury; a suspected policy breach at a customer site	Line manager **the same working day**; incident form in PeopleHub.
Severity 4 — Low	A near miss; a hazard; a minor service complaint	PeopleHub incident form **within 24 hours**.

All suspected **security** incidents must be reported within 1 hour regardless of severity (section 19.10).

21.3 Inappropriate customer behaviour

Northstar protects employees from harassment by customers and other third parties. An employee who experiences abusive, discriminatory or sexually inappropriate behaviour from a customer may end the call or meeting, or leave the location if they feel unsafe, and must report it under Table 21.2. The line manager will make sure the employee is safe, offer support, and escalate to the Account Director and People Operations. Northstar will raise the matter with the customer and may change staffing arrangements or, in serious cases, suspend services. The employee will not be penalised for ending an interaction in good faith.

21.4 Professional-conduct complaints from customers

A customer complaint about a Northstar employee's conduct is passed by the Account Director to People Operations within 1 working day. People Operations decides whether informal resolution, the disciplinary procedure (section 15) or no action is appropriate. The employee is told about the complaint and has the opportunity to respond before any decision.

21.5 Incidents at a customer site

Follow the customer's site incident procedure and also report to Northstar using Table 21.2. Security incidents involving customer systems are reported to both the customer contact named in the engagement plan and Northstar IT Security.

21.6 Evidence

Record the date, time, location, people involved, what happened and any witnesses as soon as possible. Keep emails, chat messages and screenshots; do not delete or edit them. Do not record conversations covertly. Do not copy customer data to personal devices as evidence; IT Security will preserve system evidence.

21.7 Manager actions

The manager acknowledges the report the same working day, makes sure the employee is safe, escalates according to Table 21.2, records actions taken in the PeopleHub incident record, and follows up with the employee within 5 working days.

22 Organisation changes, redundancy, resignation and termination

22.1 Organisation changes and internal transfers

When Northstar proposes changes that affect employees' roles, reporting lines or locations, affected employees are informed and consulted before decisions are finalised. Internal transfers follow section 2.5.

22.2 Redundancy

A redundancy situation arises where Northstar needs fewer employees to do work of a particular kind, or work ceases at a location. Northstar will consult individually with affected employees, use fair and objective selection criteria, consider ways to avoid redundancy and offer suitable alternative employment where available. Where it proposes 20 or more redundancies at one establishment within 90 days, Northstar will also carry out collective consultation in line with the statutory minimum periods and notify the Secretary of State.

> **Statutory redundancy pay**
> Employees with at least 2 years' continuous service are entitled to statutory redundancy pay: half a week's pay for each full year of service under age 22; one week's pay for each full year aged 22 to 40; and one and a half weeks' pay for each full year aged 41 or over. Service is capped at 20 years. For redundancies on or after 6 April 2026, weekly pay is capped at £751 and the maximum statutory redundancy payment is £22,530. Any enhanced redundancy terms are discretionary and will be confirmed in writing at the time; none are guaranteed by this handbook.

Employees under notice of redundancy with at least 2 years' service may take reasonable paid time off to look for work or arrange training.

22.3 Resignation

Employees resign by giving written notice (email is acceptable) to their line manager, copied to people@northstar.example. Notice starts on the day after it is received. Resignation in the heat of the moment, followed quickly by retraction, will be discussed with the employee before it is accepted.

22.4 Notice periods

Table 22.4 — Notice periods

Situation	Notice the employee must give (contractual)	Notice Northstar must give
During probation	1 week	1 week
After probation, grades G1 to G3	1 month	The greater of 1 month and the statutory minimum
After probation, grades G4 and G5	2 months	The greater of 2 months and the statutory minimum
After probation, grades G6 and G7	3 months	The greater of 3 months and the statutory minimum

Statutory minimum notice
An employee with more than 1 month's service must give at least 1 week's notice. An employer must give at least 1 week's notice to an employee with between 1 month and 2 years' service, then 1 week for each complete year of service from 2 years, up to a maximum of 12 weeks after 12 years. A contract can give more than these minimums but never less. Notice periods in Table 22.4 are illustrative Northstar contractual terms; the individual employment contract prevails.

Example. Northstar gives notice to a G2 engineer with 9 complete years of service. Contractual notice is 1 month; statutory notice is 9 weeks. Northstar must give **9 weeks**' notice because it is longer. If the same engineer resigns, they need give only their contractual notice of 1 month.

22.5 Pay in lieu of notice

Where the contract contains a pay in lieu of notice clause, Northstar may end employment immediately or part-way through notice by paying basic salary for the remaining notice period.

22.6 Garden leave

Northstar may require an employee to stay away from work and not contact customers or colleagues for all or part of their notice period. During garden leave the employee remains employed, receives full pay and benefits, remains bound by their duties, and may be required to take accrued annual leave (section 6.16). System access is removed at the start of garden leave.

22.7 Handover

Within 5 working days of notice being given, the employee and line manager agree a handover plan covering work in progress, customer contacts, documents and access to shared resources.

22.8 Outstanding expenses and corporate cards

All outstanding expense claims must be submitted within 10 working days after the leaving date (section 12.3). Corporate cards are cancelled on the last working day; any personal spend or unreconciled amount is recovered as described in section 11.10.

22.9 Equipment return and access revocation

Equipment is returned in line with section 20.6. System and building access is revoked at **17:30 on the last working day**, or immediately on dismissal without notice or at the start of garden leave.

22.10 Exit interviews

People Operations offers an optional exit interview in the final 2 weeks of employment. Feedback is reported in anonymised form.

22.11 Final pay and outstanding annual leave

Salary is paid for the calendar month on the 25th (section 11.1). If the leaving date is **on or before** the 10th of a month, all final pay, including payment for untaken annual leave, approved expenses and any deductions, is paid on the 25th of that month. If the leaving date is **after** the 10th, normal salary for that month is paid on the 25th and the final adjustments (holiday pay, expenses and deductions) are paid on the 25th of the following month. The final holiday balance is calculated as set out in section 6.17.

22.12 Confidentiality and references

Confidentiality obligations and any post-termination restrictions in the contract continue after employment ends. Only People Operations provides references on Northstar's behalf; these confirm dates of employment and job title only. Managers may give personal references only if they make clear in writing that the reference is personal and not given on Northstar's behalf.

22.13 Employee exit checklist

Table 22.13 — Employee exit checklist

Action	Owner	Deadline
Written resignation or notice letter recorded in PeopleHub	Line manager / People Operations	Within 2 working days of notice
Handover plan agreed	Employee and line manager	Within 5 working days of notice
Remaining annual leave reviewed and booked or planned	Employee and line manager	Within 5 working days of notice
Outstanding expenses submitted	Employee	Within 10 working days after leaving date
Corporate card cancelled	Finance	Last working day
Equipment and access card returned	Employee	Last working day (office-based) or within 5 working days after leaving date (remote or hybrid)
System and building access revoked	IT	17:30 on last working day
Exit interview offered	People Operations	Final 2 weeks
Final pay calculated (holiday balance, deductions, expenses)	Payroll	Per section 22.11
P45 issued	Payroll	With final pay

23 Policy exceptions and interpretation

23.1 Who may approve exceptions

Table 23.1 — Exception approval authority

Rule	Approver	Maximum duration
Annual leave notice, coverage limits and critical delivery periods	Head of Department	Single request
Annual leave carryover beyond the standard 5 days	Director of People Operations	To 30 June of the next leave year
Expense up to 25% above a published limit	Head of Department	Single claim
Expense more than 25% above a published limit	Director	Single claim
Late expense claim more than 90 days old	Finance Director	Single claim
Hybrid attendance below the 8-days-in-4-weeks standard	Head of Department (up to 3 months); Director of People Operations (longer)	12 months
Work from abroad beyond 10 working days	Director of People Operations	20 working days in any rolling 12 months
IT security control or AI tool exception	CISO (with DPO for personal data)	6 months
Any other non-statutory people policy rule	Director of People Operations	12 months

23.2 Requirements for every exception

- Exceptions must be requested and approved **in writing** before they take effect, using the Exception Record in PeopleHub (or ExpenseFlow for expense exceptions), stating the reason, the scope, the start and end dates, and the approver.
- An exception lasts no longer than the maximum in Table 23.1 and is reviewed before it expires; it is not renewed automatically.
- If the usual approver has a conflict of interest (for example, the request concerns their own relative or their own expenses), the request goes to the next level of authority.
- An exception applies only to the individual case. It does not set a precedent and does not change the policy.
- **No exception can override mandatory law**, reduce a statutory right, breach a contractual term without the employee's agreement, or result in unlawful discrimination.

23.3 Interpretation

Questions about the meaning of a policy are decided by the policy owner. Interpretations that affect more than one case are published as policy notes. Headings and examples are for guidance; the rules themselves prevail.

24 Appendices and quick-reference resources

Appendix A — Glossary and acronyms

Table A — Acronyms

Acronym	Meaning
AWE	Average weekly earnings
CISO	Chief Information Security Officer
DPIA	Data Protection Impact Assessment
DPO	Data Protection Officer
DSAR	Data subject access request
DSE	Display screen equipment
ELT	Executive Leadership Team
EWC	Expected week of childbirth
FTE	Full-time equivalent
HoD	Head of Department
KIT / SPLIT	Keeping-in-touch day / Shared parental leave in touch day
MFA	Multifactor authentication
OH	Occupational Health
PILON	Pay in lieu of notice
PIP	Performance improvement plan
RIDDOR	Reporting of Injuries, Diseases and Dangerous Occurrences Regulations 2013
SAP / SMP / SPP / ShPP	Statutory Adoption / Maternity / Paternity / Shared Parental Pay
SSP	Statutory Sick Pay
TOIL	Time off in lieu

Appendix B — Contact and escalation directory

Table B — Contact and escalation directory

Need	First contact	Escalation
Policy questions, leave, absence, PeopleHub	people@northstar.example	Director of People Operations
Payroll and pay errors	payroll@northstar.example	Head of Payroll
Expenses and corporate cards	expenses@northstar.example	Finance Director
Business travel bookings and travel risk	travel@northstar.example	Finance Director
IT support, equipment, lost devices	ithelp@northstar.example; IT Service Desk internal extension 5000	Head of IT Operations
Security incidents (24/7)	security@northstar.example; 24/7 security line internal extension 5999	CISO
Data protection and DSARs	dpo@northstar.example	Data Protection Officer
Whistleblowing	speakup@northstar.example; Speak Up line via intranet	Head of Risk and Compliance; Chair of the Audit Committee
Conflicts, gifts and anti-bribery	compliance@northstar.example	Head of Risk and Compliance
Health and safety	safety@northstar.example	Head of Facilities and Health and Safety
Wellbeing	Employee Assistance Programme (24/7, details on intranet)	People Operations
Hybrid working and work from abroad	workplace@northstar.example	Head of Workplace Experience

Appendix C — Leave entitlement summary

Table C — Leave entitlement summary (current from 1 October 2026)

Leave type	Entitlement	Section
Annual leave (full-time)	27 days; 28 after 3 years; 29 after 5 years; plus 8 bank holidays	6.1
Carryover	Up to 5 days, use by 31 March	6.11
Company sick pay	4 to 13 weeks full pay plus equal half pay, by service, after probation	7.5
Paternity leave	2 weeks (day one); full pay if eligible for SPP	8.2
Unpaid parental leave	18 weeks per child (day one); max 4 weeks per child per year	8.5
Carer's leave	1 week per 12 months (day one); first 3 days paid	8.8
Time off for dependants	Reasonable time (day one); 2 paid days per occurrence, max 5 paid days per year	8.8
Compassionate leave	Up to 5 days for immediate family	9.1
Jury service	Time off; full pay for first 10 working days per leave year	9.3
Volunteering	2 paid days per leave year	9.11

Appendix D — Absence reporting checklist

1. Call your line manager by 09:30 (or 1 hour before your shift).
2. Record the absence in PeopleHub the same day.
3. Update your manager on day 3 and then weekly.

4. Absent more than 7 calendar days? Upload a fit note within 3 working days of it being issued.
5. Complete self-certification in PeopleHub on your first day back.
6. Attend the return-to-work conversation within 2 working days of returning.

Appendix E — Expense approval matrix

See Table 12.6. Pre-approval is additionally required for overnight stays, international travel, any single item over £250, client entertainment, premium travel classes and learning-budget spend (section 12.2).

Appendix F — Responsibility (RACI) matrix

Table F — RACI matrix for key people processes (R = Responsible, A = Accountable, C = Consulted, I = Informed)

Process	Employee	Line manager	HoD	People Ops	Finance	IT
Annual leave request	R	A	C	I	–	–
Sickness reporting	R	A	I	C	–	–
Flexible-working request	R	A	C	C	–	–
Expense claim	R	A	C	–	C	–
Equipment return on leaving	R	I	–	A	–	C
Security incident report	R	I	I	–	–	A
Probation review	C	R	I	A	–	–
Work from abroad request	R	C	–	A	–	C

Appendix G — Policy ownership table

See Table 1.6.

Appendix H — Document version history

Table H — Version history of Northstar people policy documents

Document ID	Title	Version	Effective period	Status
NDS-HR-HB-001	Employee Handbook	1.0	1 Jan 2025 – 30 Jun 2025	Superseded (not in corpus)
NDS-HR-HB-001	Employee Handbook	1.1	1 Jul 2025 – 30 Sep 2026	Superseded (not in corpus)
NDS-HR-HB-001	Employee Handbook	2.0	From 1 Oct 2026	Current
NDS-HR-LV-006	Leave Policy	1.0	1 Jan 2025 – 30 Sep 2026	Superseded (archived)
NDS-HR-LAS-002	Leave and Absence Standard	1.2	From 1 Oct 2026	Current
NDS-FIN-EXP-003	Expenses and Business Travel Policy	1.1	From 1 Oct 2026	Current
NDS-SEC-ITG-004	IT Security, Data Protection and Generative AI Policy	2.0	From 1 Oct 2026	Current
NDS-HR-HFW-005	Hybrid and Flexible Working Standard	1.1	From 1 Oct 2026	Current

Appendix I — Employee acknowledgement form

I confirm that I have received, read and understood the Northstar Employee Handbook NDS-HR-HB-001 version 2.0, effective 1 October 2026, and the supporting standards it refers to. I understand that the handbook does not form part of my contract of employment except where it expressly says so, and that I can ask People Operations about anything I do not understand.

Acknowledgement record

Field	Entry
Employee name	
Employee number	
Department	
Signature (or PeopleHub e-acknowledgement)	
Date	

Appendix J — Frequently encountered scenarios

Table J — Common scenarios and where to look

Scenario	Policy route
"I want two weeks off in August."	Request in PeopleHub with at least 20 working days' notice (section 6.6); subject to team coverage (section 6.7).
"I was ill on the second day of my holiday."	Report by 09:30 on the first day of sickness and provide evidence; days can be re-credited (section 6.12).
"My child's nursery closed unexpectedly today."	Time off for dependants; up to 2 paid days (section 8.8).
"I want to work from Spain for a week."	Work From Abroad request at least 4 weeks ahead; maximum 10 working days in 12 months (section 10.8).
"I lost my laptop on the train."	Report to IT within 1 hour and to the police within 24 hours (section 20.3).
"I forgot to claim a hotel from 7 weeks ago."	Late claim (31–90 days): explanation and HoD approval (section 12.3).
"Can I paste a customer's incident log into an AI tool?"	Only an approved tool, only if the customer contract permits and the log contains no Restricted information (section 19.12).
"A customer made sexual comments on a call."	Severity 2: report within 1 hour; you may end the call (section 21.3).
"I'm resigning but have leave left."	Agree leave during notice or receive payment for untaken leave (sections 6.16 and 6.17).
"My manager hasn't replied to my leave request for a week."	It is not approved by default; PeopleHub escalates to the HoD after 5 working days (section 6.7).

Appendix K — Policy decision and escalation flow

1. **Is the question about a legal right?** If yes, the statutory rule applies as a minimum. Go to step 2 to check for any company enhancement.
2. **Does the employee's contract say something specific?** If yes, the contract applies (unless it gives less than the law).
3. **Is there a current topic-specific standard?** If yes, apply it. Check the document's status is "Current" and that its effective date covers the date in question.
4. **Otherwise apply this handbook**, then any manager guidance.
5. **Does the situation fall outside the rule?** Consider whether an exception is appropriate under section 23, and record it in writing.

6. **Still unsure?** Raise a PeopleHub "Policy clarification" case. Do not rely on an archived document or on unwritten practice.

Appendix L — Quick-reference index

Table L — Quick-reference index

Topic	Section
Annual leave, holiday, PTO, time off	6; NDS-HR-LAS-002 section 3
Bank and public holidays	6.5
Bereavement, compassionate leave	9.1
Bonus	11.7
Carryover of holiday	6.11
Conflicts of interest	14.3
Data breach	18.7
Expenses	12; NDS-FIN-EXP-003
Flexible working	10.6; NDS-HR-HFW-005
Generative AI	19.12; NDS-SEC-ITG-004
Gifts and hospitality	14.4
Grievance	15.6
Notice periods	22.4
Overtime and TOIL	5.5
Parental, maternity, paternity leave	8
Pension	11.11
Probation	2.3
Sick pay and sickness reporting	7
Whistleblowing	16
Work from abroad	10.8

References — statutory sources

The statutory positions summarised in this handbook were checked against the official sources below on **13 October 2026** for this synthetic edition. Statutory rates usually change each April. Items marked "Legal review" were not independently re-verified in this check or depend on future commencement dates, and must be confirmed by People Operations or legal counsel before being relied on.

Table R — Statutory references

Topic	Source	Check status
Holiday entitlement (5.6 weeks, 28-day cap)	https://www.gov.uk/holiday-entitlement-rights	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Bank holidays 2026 and 2027	https://www.gov.uk/bank-holidays	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Statutory Sick Pay rate and fit notes	https://www.gov.uk/statutory-sick-pay	Verified 13 Oct 2026
SSP from day one, removal of lower earnings limit (6 April 2026)	Employment Rights Act 2025; implementation timeline summarised by employment-law publishers	Verified via secondary source; Legal review
Maternity leave and SMP	https://www.gov.uk/maternity-pay-leave	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Paternity leave and SPP (day-one leave)	https://www.gov.uk/paternity-pay-leave	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Adoption leave and SAP eligibility	https://www.gov.uk/adoption-pay-leave	Eligibility verified; SAP rate structure Legal review
Shared parental leave and pay	https://www.gov.uk/shared-parental-leave-and-pay	50 weeks / 37 weeks / 8 weeks' notice verified; booking-notice rules Legal review
Unpaid parental leave	https://www.gov.uk/parental-leave	Entitlement and notice verified; postponement rule Legal review
Neonatal care leave and pay	https://www.acas.org.uk/neonatal-care-leave-and-pay	Verified 13 Oct 2026; pay earnings threshold Legal review
Parental bereavement leave and pay	https://www.gov.uk/parental-bereavement-pay-leave	Leave and rate verified; pay eligibility Legal review
Carer's leave	https://www.gov.uk/carers-leave	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Time off for dependants	https://www.gov.uk/time-off-for-dependants	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Partner antenatal appointments; KIT and SPLIT days	GOV.UK and Acas guidance	Legal review
Flexible working (day one, 2 requests, 2 months, refusal reasons)	https://www.gov.uk/flexible-working	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Jury service time off and deferral	https://www.gov.uk/giving-staff-time-off-jury-service	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Notice periods (employee and employer minimums)	https://www.gov.uk/handing-in-your-notice; https://www.gov.uk/redundant-your-rights/notice-periods	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Statutory redundancy pay and cap	https://www.gov.uk/redundant-your-rights/redundancy-pay	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Collective consultation thresholds and periods	GOV.UK and Acas guidance on redundancy consultation	Legal review
Workplace pension minimum contributions and qualifying earnings	https://www.gov.uk/workplace-pensions/what-you-your-employer-and-the-government-pay	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Approved mileage rates 2026/27	https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/rates-and-allowances-travel-mileage-and-fuel-allowances/travel-mileage-and-fuel-rates-and-allowances	Verified 13 Oct 2026
Working Time Regulations 1998 limits and rest breaks	https://www.gov.uk/working-time-limits-the-48-hour-week	Legal review (page not retrievable during check)
Strengthened sexual harassment duty (expected 30 October 2026); unfair dismissal qualifying period (expected 1 January 2027); bereavement leave (expected 2027)	Employment Rights Act 2025 implementation roadmap	Legal review

Topic	Source	Check status
Data protection (UK GDPR, DSAR timescales, 72-hour breach notification)	https://ico.org.uk	Legal review